Chipped

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53281135.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Poor Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer Friendship (She-Ra), Implied/Referenced Torture, Psychological Torture, Episode: s05e03 Corridors, Post-Episode: s05e03 Corridors, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Tags May Change, Rating May Change

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Chipped

by AstrynSerene

Summary

What if Catra didn't succeed in saving Glimmer?

What if Darla never changed course?

What happens when there's a change of heart?

Aboard the Velvet Glove

Chapter Notes

I've always been a fan of canon divergence AUs, and I've wanted to make one surrounding season five for a long time. Recently during a late night ADHD brainstorming session, my brain posed the questions "What if Catra failed to save Glimmer? What if they got captured, and the others on Darla along with them?"

The start of this AU is in the episode "Corridors" [S5 EP3]. It diverges fairly quickly from the original script, and we'll get a little more insight into what I think was going through Catra's mind.

Fair warning that this story is going to get very dark at times when it comes to Prime's methods of getting what he wants. The ending will be happy though! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra gulped as she walked down the hallway towards Glimmer's holding cell, a small box in hand. She tentatively stepped into the cell once the clone escorting her opened it.

"What's with the babysitter?" Glimmer asked, an amused smile forming on her face.

Catra opened her mouth, but paused, looking back at the clone, "Give us some privacy?"

“Of course, sister. Prime sees all!” The clone exclaimed, before reactivating the forcefield and removing the transparency.

“Sister..?” Glimmer raised an eyebrow, now looking confused and concerned.

Catra simply shook her head, clearly uncomfortable before holding out the box, “Here. It’s the dumb food you wanted.”

The queen smiled as she took it, opening the box.

“You know, from your ‘perfect day’ or whatever?”

“Yeah, I remember. Just- thanks…” Glimmer hummed, setting the box on the table she had before looking back at the brunette, “But I know that isn’t the only reason you’re here.”

“Yeah, I’m supposed to talk to you, so just eat the stupid cake and answer my questions.” She said, purposely louder as the two noticed the silhouette of the clone outside the cell seemingly at the same time.

“Catra.. What’s going on?” Glimmer whispered, flinching when she was guided back to sit on the bed as Catra knelt in front of her.

“Just look at me,” Catra whispered, suddenly urgent and.. afraid? Glimmer felt her own fear growing at the sight of such a foreign expression on Catra's face, “An old First One’s ship left Etheria’s atmosphere a few days ago and Prime cannot track it. What do you know about it?”

Glimmer gasped, eyes widening.

Catra’s quickly followed, “...Adora’s on that ship, isn’t she?”

The queen could only nod, “Y-You can’t tell him!” She whisper-yelled, grabbing the magicat’s hands, “If- if he catches her he- he can use her to activate the Heart and wipe out the *whole* universe!”

Catra gasped softly, getting to her feet and pulling her hands from Glimmer’s.

“Catra, *please* -!”

“What can I do, Glimmer?” Catra suddenly snapped, turning back to the queen, who gasped upon seeing tears in the brunette’s eyes, “It doesn’t matter if I tell him or not, she’s coming here for you.”

Guilt crept up from Glimmer’s chest. She found herself at a loss for words, knowing that what was going to happen to Adora and Etheria would be her fault.

Catra stood there awkwardly, blinking away tears as she turned back towards the door.

Then she remembered the teleportation room she'd seen earlier, and her ears perked up. She turned back to the queen, placing a hand on her shoulder to get her attention.

"I'll be back in a few hours." She whispered as quietly as possible into Glimmer's ear.

"Why… what-?" Her eyes widened when she recognized the look in Catra's eyes. She was planning something, "Catra what-"

Without another word, Catra walked up to the forcefield and banged on it a couple times, "Hey! You can let me out now!"

Once Catra was gone, Glimmer could only stare, her emotions too mixed to name. Was Catra going to try what she thought she was going to, and if so… what would happen to Catra?

⚔

"It is as our sister said. We have done a sweep of all quadrants in our vicinity, and we have located the Etherian ship. It is almost here."

Catra had wanted to avoid this meeting with her entire being, but the moment she left Glimmer's holding cell, she had immediately been flanked by two clones and brought back before Prime to report her findings. She had been as vague as possible without being suspicious, simply confirming that the First One's ship was indeed She-Ra, and that she was coming to save Glimmer.

"You have done well, little sister. Soon, She-Ra will be mine. And with her, Etheria. All because of you." Catra felt waves of nausea trying to fight its way up. She had to focus all of her energy to keep herself from throwing up, " ...You made the right choice. You will be exalted, raised up above the other wretched creatures of your home world. ...Is that not what you wanted?"

No . It was not at all even *close* to what she wanted. But she couldn't say that out loud, she doubted what she truly wanted would ever be a reality. She had been raised to play a villain after all, "Yes, Lord Prime."

"Go now in peace." Prime ended the conversation simply before turning back towards his wall of monitors.

Catra couldn't get out of that room fast enough.

⚔

She spent the next few hours wandering the ship, memories of her childhood and the fantasies of the life she wished she could have been blessed with.

Her opportunity came when she rounded the corner to see a clone approaching Glimmer's holding cell with a tray of food. Smirking, she silently snuck up behind them, before making her move; jumping on top of their back and ramming her hand into the port on the back of their neck, "It's nothing personal… Hordak." She huffed, grabbing the clone's wrist, "I'm coming in!" She called to give the queen a warning before using the clone's hand to take down the forcefield.

"Catra… what are you doing?" Glimmer asked, clutching the leg of a chair.

"Trying to do one good thing in my life. I'm getting you out of here, so let's go." She explained, holding out her hand.

Though hesitant, she had no other options for escape. Slowly, she took the magicat's hand, following her into the hallway as they began to race down the corridor, "What is your plan here exactly?"

"To keep everyone important away from him."

"But-" Glimmer froze as they rounded the corner, where three clones were standing around that quickly surrounded them.

“Little sister, why is our guest out of her quarters?”

“She wanted to get some fresh air. Didn’t you-” Catra smirked as she leapt forward, perching on the clone’s shoulders as she rammed into the clone’s port, “- *princess* ?!”

Glimmer grunted as she swung the chair leg at the second clone, but the third one grabbed it and tossed it down the hall before she could attempt to do any real damage with it.

Catra tackled the second clone before it could advance on Glimmer, “Hit them in the back of the neck, that should take them down!” she called quickly. The queen nodded, shoving the final clone and driving her fists against the port on its neck, sending it to the floor.

“Not bad, Sparkles.” Catra chuckled, before flinching at a sudden alarm that began to blare throughout the ship, blinking red lights accompanying it, “Let’s go!”

As the girls raced into the teleportation room, Catra was quick to grab Glimmer’s arm and pull her up onto the teleportation pad, the field rising once Catra stepped back to the console, quickly closing the doors.

“Wait- Catra what are you doing?”

“What does it *look* like? I’m getting you out of here!”

“But- but what about you?” The queen pressed her hands to the glass.

“Me? All I do is hurt people. There’s nobody left in the entire universe who cares about me.”

“ *What* ? But-” Glimmer was cut off by the clones banging on the door trying to get through. Catra turned her attention back to the console, biting her lip and waiting, *praying* that Adora would respond to her call.

A small wave of relief washed over her when the line picked up, “Adora?”

She heard a faint gasp, “ *Catra..!?* ”

“Don’t sound so happy to hear me. I’m sending Glimmer to you. I don’t know your exact location, but I can get her to your quadrant. You *have* to be there to catch her.”

“ *Wait wait wait- what’s going on? G- Glimmer is with you* ?”

Catra gasped as the clones forced the door open, "No time! You- You need to get to these coordinates now! Don't come here! No matter-" Catra yelped as she was roughly grabbed and slammed against the wall by clones, "No!"

"Catra!" Glimmer exclaimed, pressing her hands to the field like it would make it magically disappear.

" *Catra I don't understand what's happening-* " Adora tried, her concerned voice growing more worried by the second.

"Ghm- let me go!" Catra yelled, struggling against the clones holding her arms against the wall, "Adora, do *not* come here! He's ready for you! He's going to-" The brunette cried out as she was shoved forward on her knees while her arms were twisted roughly behind her.

" *Catra!? Catra-!* " The communication line was cut off by a clone, shutting down the machine and by extension, lowering the forcefield. Glimmer yelped as she was yanked off and her arms were pulled behind her. She grunted when she felt metal cuffs lock her arms in place. She looked up in fear as she was dragged out of the room by one clone, Catra by another, the two only a few feet apart.

They both knew they were being taken to Prime, but had no idea what he was going to do to them now. Would he just lock them back up, or get rid of them for good?

“I’m so sorry, Glimmer…” Catra managed, tears running down her face. The queen looked at her, eyes welling up as they approached the entrance to the main deck where Prime’s throne was, “...for everything.”

Chapter End Notes

I can't wait to hear what you think about this prologue-esque beginning!

Into the Light

Chapter Summary

Adora, Bow, and Entrapta arrive at the Velvet Glove. Everyone is terrified of what Prime might do to them and their home.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everyone stared in shock and fear as the communication line went dead. What had just happened?

"Do we- still need to go to those coordinates?" Entrapta slowly asked.

"I don't think so, but we do need to get to Prime's ship as fast as possible now." Adora replied, taking a deep breath. Catra *wasn't* on Etheria? She was with *him* ? How did that even happen!?

Bow turned to the scientist, expression grave, "Entrapta, do whatever it takes to get us there."

Gasping and eyes sparkling, Entrapta squealed and rushed to the console, tapping a few buttons and drawing a scream out of the other two when Darla suddenly blasted off at a much higher speed than before.

⚔

Adora held her breath as Darla approached the Velvet Glove. They had absolutely no plan, no She-Ra, and no idea what was waiting for them. All they had was bluffs they could only pray would work and hope they could rescue their friends and escape in one piece.

The trio gasped when Darla began to sound an alarm.

Warning. We are being pulled in by an unknown force .

"Alright… this is it." Adora sighed, sadly smiling at Bow when he grasped her hand.

When Darla landed, the passengers were jostled around, Bow and Adora holding onto each other while Entrapta held onto the pilot chair to stay on their feet.

Once steady, they shared uncertain and frightened expressions as they slowly made their way to the exit ramp.

As soon as the ramp lowered, they were met with three clones waiting for them. Immediately, they advanced, one grabbing each of them and pulling their arms behind them. Adora groaned, feeling like her arms were being crushed underneath the clone's hold.

"You will be brought before Prime, where you will each receive your judgment." The clone holding Adora said, before they were

forced to walk down the ramp and into the hallway off the ship docking station.

As they were led down the hallway, Adora focused on channeling her anger to bury her fear as much as possible. Thinking about what Prime could have done in the time Glimmer, and apparently Catra, had already been here was enough to push down concern for herself for the moment.

She grunted when they entered the main room, and the clone holding her pushed her forward to stand before Prime's throne while the other two were held a bit behind her.

Adora fixed her expression with a glare, straightening her posture as she stared at the back of the throne, " *Prime* ."

"Welcome… Adora."

The blonde flinched, not expecting him to know her name.

"Forgive my- unseemly state. It's quite the task to maintain this vessel." He spoke calmly, his throne turning to face his guests as the tubes providing the amniotic fluids were disconnected.

"This is how things are going to go. You're going to give me Catra and Glimmer, then you're going to let us all leave again, free and clear. I'm sure you're aware by now that Etheria possesses a

weapon that only She-Ra can activate," She touched her hand to her chest for emphasis, "and if you don't do as I say, then I'll use it to destroy you and your empire- for good."

Prime eyed her, each blinking in sequence one after another.

Then he began to laugh.

Adora recoiled in surprise, growing annoyed as her fists clenched, "Is… is something *funny* ?"

"You are not going to use the weapon, or you would have already *done* so." Prime smirked, rising from his throne and descending the store staircase to approach Adora, "You would not risk the safety of Glimmer or Your Catra."

Adora narrowed her eyes, "You don't know me. And you don't know what I'm capable of."

"Oh, but I *do* ." He suddenly grabbed her by her chin, drawing a gasp from her, "I'm older than you can ever imagine. I faced your ancestors, the ones you call 'First Ones'.." He smirked when Adora grew unnerved at the mention, "..You are one of them, are you not, Adora?"

Adora's eyes widened, wincing when his hold on her face tightened.

“I crushed their once mighty empire beneath my heel, I thought they were all gone. Clearly some faction remains.”

Hardening her glare, Adora yanked her face free of his hold, “I don't fight for the First Ones. I fight for Etheria, for my friends, and for myself! Now for the last time- Where are they?!”

Prime smiled, “Of course. I've heard it's been quite some time since you've seen each other.” Prime motioned behind them, the three turning as Glimmer was forced into the room, arms cuffed in front of her, a clone holding the end of the chain to guide her. Her ankles were also cuffed, a chain long enough to keep her from tripping connected her legs. Other than exhaustion and her terrified expression, she looked unharmed.

Catra, however, while bound the same way, looked much worse for wear. Her headpiece was missing, her hair disheveled like it hadn't been brushed in days. Her face had several bruises, and her bottom lip was cut. Her hands were clenched into fists, but less like she was ready to fight and more like she was hiding her fingers. Her bodysuit had several tears around the collar. The only similarity between the two aside from their restraints was that both of their faces were wet with tears.

Adora and Bow gasped, the archer tearing up while Adora immediately tried to lunge for them, only to be grabbed by the clone behind her and forced to her knees, “Catra!”

“A-Adora..!” Catra groaned as the clone holding her chains yanked her against them.

“What did you do to her?!” Adora yelled, fury trampling all other emotions.

Ignoring her question, Prime approached the two. Catra gasped and whined when he grabbed her shoulder.

“Don’t touch her!!” Adora snapped, struggling against the clone holding her down.

“Do not fear, Adora. I have great plans for each of you. But for now, my clones will show you to your quarters. It's been quite the day for us all.”

⚔

When they were brought back to the holding cell, Glimmer and Catra were released from their restraints, the group left alone once the forcefield was raised and returned to its opaque state.

As soon as they were alone, the others looked at Catra and Glimmer, “Are you two okay?!” Adora asked, eyes glossed over with tears.

Glimmer shook her head, “We’re… I’m fine.”

Adora turned her attention to Catra, “What did he do to you…?”

Shaking her head, Catra curled up in the corner of the room.

“Catra..” The blonde slowly moved over to sit next to her, “Please.. talk to me..”

Glimmer frowned, “Catra, it’s okay…”

The brunette looked up, the two seeming to share a silent conversation before Catra turned her attention to Adora. Her lip quivered, tears beginning to run down her face, “A-Adora I- I’m so sorry I- I tried so h-hard.. I wanted to do one g-good thing-”

“Hey, hey..” Adora wrapped her arms around her, pulling her into a gentle hug, “It wasn’t your fault.”

“I-I’m sorry for- for everything else too…”

“I’m sorry too…” Adora whispered, smiling when Catra finally returned the embrace, “I wish I could heal you.. I’m so sorry…”

Catra shook her head, “I don’t deserve that..”

“Catra…” Adora blinked away tears, holding the brunette closer.

Glimmer finally looked to Bow, who was sitting next to Entrapta near the door, fidgeting with his hands, “Bow..” she called quietly, scooting a little closer, “I- I’m so sorry too…to all of you actually..” She started, gaining everyone’s attention, “If I had just- *listened* to Adora and Bow and didn’t let Shadow Weaver manipulate me we wouldn’t be in this situation right now..”

“What do you mean..?” Catra sniffed, “If I didn’t pull that lever Hordak wouldn’t have gotten a message through…”

“But he wouldn’t have been able to find us if I didn’t use the Heart’s magic to pull us out of Despondos…”

“Everyone could have made better choices, alright?” Bow said, gently taking Glimmer’s hand into his own, “Adora and I could have tried harder to get through to you instead of leaving you to run to Beast Island.”

“I should have understood your point of view better..” Adora added, “I knew you were talking to Shadow Weaver and how good she is at getting into your head. We’ve relied on magic for years, it’s completely understandable for you to want to use it. If we had taken the time to show you what we saw, maybe things would have turned out differently.”

“But we can’t change what happened. Now, all that matters is that we’re together.” Bow smiled slightly, “We… may have never been in a situation this bad before, but we always find a way.”

“I don’t know what you expect us to do right now besides wait.” Catra muttered.

“Well, while we do that- can one of you tell me what happened to Catra..?” Adora asked, still wanting nothing more than to rain the fury of herself and She-Ra on that monster.

Catra looked at Glimmer, giving a soft nod before burying her face against her knees.

Glimmer took a deep breath, “He uhm… interrogated her for information.”

“About what?”

“Well…” Glimmer squeezed Bow’s hand, “You.”

“Me…?” Adora furrowed her eyebrows.

“Well, your relationship with Catra, anyway…”

“Why would he care about that?”

The queen took another deep breath, “I don't want to put Catra's inner thoughts and emotions more on display than they already have been. Just know that- he knows a lot about both of you, and you need to be careful.”

Adora was still confused, but understood enough. She looked back at Catra, taking her hand, “Well, whatever the case may be, I need you to know that I'm never leaving you again, Catra.”

Sniffing, the brunette looked up at her.

“Yeah, despite the past few years, you're stuck with us now.” Glimmer smiled. After everything she'd heard and seen today, she felt weirdly protective over Catra. It was odd going from an enemy of almost four years to an ally and, dare she think, friend, in under twenty four hours, but stranger things have happened she supposed.

Catra couldn't stop the tiny smile that formed, “Thanks, Sparkles…”

“Of course, Horde Scum.” Glimmer replied, the two giggling.

The sight made Adora want to squeal with joy. She would definitely be commenting on it later.

“I know it's probably not ideal, but we should probably try and get some sleep.” Bow finally spoke up. Entrapta was the only one a step ahead, as she'd fallen asleep against Bow's shoulder ten minutes ago.

“Shouldn't someone stay up? Just in case..?” Glimmer asked.

“I will.” Adora volunteered, “On the way here we did the same thing, and Bow had the last shift.”

Nodding, Glimmer slowly stood, making her way over to sit next to Catra. Bow followed once he lifted Entrapta into his arms.

Carefully, they all leaned on the wall or each other and slowly let exhaustion take them.

⚔

The others were able to sleep for close to five hours. Adora didn't fall asleep until around five minutes before the forcefield was lowered and a group of clones were revealed. Adora flinched when she heard their approaching footsteps.

“Good morning, guests. Prime hopes you had a decent time of rest.”

The clone's loud voice and movements abruptly woke the others.

“I'm sure he does..” Adora groaned, rolling her eyes, “What do you want?”

“Prime has decided it is time for some of you to return to Etheria.”

“I'm sorry- *some* ?” Glimmer furrowed her eyebrows, “We aren't going anywhere unless we're all together.”

“That is not a decision up to you, I'm afraid.”

The three clones advanced, one taking Entrapta's arms, one Bow's, and one Glimmer's.

Adora and Catra shared a look, eyes wide as they watched the others be dragged out of the room. They both clearly wanted to help, but everyone knew it was useless.

“We'll be back for you both, I promise!” Glimmer called, the girls nodding as the forcefield was relit, leaving them alone.

The trio gasped as they were led onto a smaller ship and pushed into a much smaller transport cell.

“Are you actually taking us back to Etheria?” Glimmer asked, crossing her arms as the forcefield blocked them inside.

“Of course. It is Prime's command!” The clone replied, “He knows you must miss your homeworld!”

“Oh yeah, send him our gratitude..” Glimmer scoffed, though the clone seemed unaware of her sarcasm.

⚔

Several hours had passed since the others had been taken away, and Adora was growing more restless by the second.

“Trust me, princess… you aren't breaking that thing…” Catra sighed, watching Adora fail to shatter the barrier with her fists.

“Well, I can't just sit here! I won't let him hurt anyone else!”

The brunette’s ears drooped, gaining Adora's attention. The blonde frowned, slowly approaching and sitting next to Catra once again, “I don't know what he made you say, but I'm so sorry…”

“Not your fault…”

“Kinda seems like it is… How did you even get here?”

“Same way Sparkles and Hordak did.”

Adora sighed. She gently took Catra's hand, “No matter what happens… we have each other.. right?”

A tiny smile made its way onto Catra's face, “Promise..?”

“I promise.”

Adora smiled and opened her arms, feeling butterflies in her stomach when Catra returned the embrace.

The two flinched when the force field lowered to reveal two clones, “Prime has requested an audience with you both.”

Sighing, Adora stood up, Catra doing the same. They slowly approached, allowing the clones to escort them down the hallway. Clearly it was better to just follow rather than be forcibly dragged.

The two shared a worried look when they were led into the room where Prime held his baptismal chamber. Prime approached with a

calm smile, “I trust you had a pleasant night.”

“Being awoken to my friends being taken away from me isn’t exactly pleasant.” Adora glared, “Did you really send them back to Etheria?”

“Of course I did. They’re on their way back as we speak.”

“And what are you going to do with Adora?” Catra finally asked, furrowing her eyebrows.

“Adora is going to help me bring peace to the universe.”

“Wait what-”

Adora gasped as her arms were grabbed by one of the clones that had brought them into the room pressing her wrists together before cuffing them. Catra immediately tried to lunge for them and attack, only to be grabbed and thrown to the ground herself, “Adora!”

The blonde groaned as she was pushed towards the baptismal pool, fighting every step of the way to plant her feet.

“Prime, *please* !” Catra cried, “Do whatever you want to me, but please, *please* don’t do this to her!” Remembering what Hordak had gone through the day before in that very pool was terrifying enough, but imagining Adora having to go through the same thing was unbearable.

Prime ignored Catra, continuing to push Adora towards the pool, “Fear not, She-Ra. Soon, you will step into the Light of Horde Prime.” He said, calm and smooth, before pushing Adora forward into the electric green liquid.

Chapter End Notes

I wanted to make the apology scene kinda like the cave scene in Tangled (where Rapunzel tells Flynn about her hair and Flynn about his real name), everyone feels like they're in a hopeless situation with no way out that doesn't involve death, and want to be on good terms with no secrets between them.

Also, let me know if you wanna see the detail of how Catra ended up the way she did. It's a bit- dark, but this whole fic is, but I still like to hear opinions!

I love hearing what you think so far and what you think will happen in the future! <3

Princess of Prime

Chapter Summary

All beings must suffer to become pure.

Chapter Notes

CW// This chapter is going to show my interpretation of the Chipping Process and it's not going to be pretty. I haven't really tried to be explicit in dark fics like this before- usually opting to leave them implied or referenced. I think it's almost necessary here though, because it's going to have such heavy impacts later on!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra grunted as she was pushed into a room by a clone and walked over to a platform. Her cuffs were removed just long enough to reattach them to the ones attached to the ceiling above her. She watched as Glimmer was led to a second platform a little ways across the room and put into the same position. They exchanged fearful expressions as Prime himself entered the room.

"I apologize for the less pleasant positions, but I do find it deeply disrespectful when my guests try to leave unauthorized. Though... I find it especially discourteous when one thinks they are so worthy as to think they can betray me with no consequences." His calm expression melted to a stern glare as he towered over the trembling magicat.

Unable to stop herself, Catra scoffed, "Trust me… I'm not worth anything… but Adora and Sparkles are. So I'll do what it takes to keep them safe. Besides… You aren't exactly up keeping your own

worth being around me-” She cried out when Prime suddenly struck her across her face. The impact dug the side of her headpiece into her cheek.

“I'd watch your tongue speaking to me that way, little sister.”

“ *Fuck* . *You* .” Catra growled, “If you're gonna kill me just do it!”

Prime narrowed his eyes, roughly grabbing her face again. His finger moved harshly enough against her bottom lip to cut it and draw blood, “If I wanted to kill you, I'd have already done so. I could, however, see to it you lose your claws one by one until you learn some respect.” He spoke in a low and menacing tone that made Catra gasp and clench her fists, eyes widening. It made Prime smirk, “Don't think closing your hands in a fist would stop me.” He emphasized his point by grabbing her hand and forcefully straightening her fingers out.

Catra screamed, “N-No!” She cried, fighting to close her hand again.

Glimmer was actively fighting her restraints now, not sure if she was more terrified or angry.

“Then I suggest you do as I say and learn who has control very quickly.”

Tears ran down Catra's face, immediately closing her fists when Prime released her hand.

“Now tell me, little sister, Adora is not really your enemy, is she?”

“S-She h-hates me…”

“Catra no-” Glimmer immediately started, only to have her shoulder roughly grabbed by a clone, “Leave her alone, *please* -!” She gasped and tensed when the clone dug their nails into her shoulder.

“This conversation doesn't concern you, your majesty.” Prime snapped, only offering a side glare before returning his attention to Catra. Glimmer glared, “You care about her.”

Catra sniffed and slowly nodded, crying out when Prime grabbed her throat.

“Use… your words.”

“Y- es..!” She gasped and coughed violently when he released her.

“You wish to be close with her again.”

"..Y-Yes!" Catra couldn't drag her gaze off of the floor.

"You wish for her to care about you in return."

"Yes!" Catra sobbed openly, head hanging as her inner thoughts and wishes were forcibly dragged out of her, "W-Why do you *c-care* !?"

Prime smirked, hooking his finger under her chin to force eye contact, "It helps to know about what She-Ra cares for most in the universe."

With that, Prime turned on his heel and left the girls alone, eagerly awaiting the arrival of the so-called Princess of Power.

⚔

" *Adora* !!" Catra cried, fighting against the clones holding her captive. Tears ran down her face, her pupils mere slits as Adora's screams echoed throughout the Velvet Glove.

Adora desperately gasped for air as she tried to fight to stay above the surface of the water. She let out a mix of cries and coughing as another surge of electricity pulsed through her body.

" *Please* ! Stop!" Catra begged, on the verge of hyperventilating herself.

With a final charge of electric currents, everything finally fell silent. Two clones stepped into the pool and lifted Adora by either arm to drag her out. The blonde was barely conscious, her head hanging and feet literally dragging on the floor as she was pulled along by the clones.

"Adora? *Adora* ?!" Catra called, desperately still trying to fight the clones restraining her.

"Fear not. Adora will be taken care of." Prime smiled, before nodding at the clones holding Catra, who began to pull her out of the room.

"Wait- what are you-"

"They will be returning you to your quarters. For now."

"No! Wait- A-Adora!" Catra tried again, gasping as she was shoved forward and forced to leave with her captors.

"C… catra…?" Adora muttered, whimpering when Prime forced her to look up at him.

“You are on your way to stepping into my Light.” He turned his attention to the clones holding her, “Assure she completes the process. Bring her to me once it is done.”

“Yes, Lord Prime.” The two replied in unison.

⚔

Adora faded in and out of consciousness as she was taken to a new room. It was similar to the holding cell, except instead of a bed stood what looked like a surgery table. A rolling cart sat next to it, various things Adora couldn't identify on top. She groaned as the clones hoisted her up and laid her down on the table.

Adora was so tired, and still feeling the aftershocks of pain from the pool. All she wanted to do was succumb to her exhaustion and sleep. Just for a few minutes.

Just.. rest…

The sudden sound of fabric ripping made her eyes shoot open. She looked just as one clone sliced through her jacket and compression top with shears, another doing the same with her pants.

Her eyes widened, and she gasped as she immediately tried to sit up, only for a third clone to grab her and hold her down, “W-What are you d-doing?! Stop!”

Ignoring her, the clones simply continued to slice through her clothing until she was left in nothing but her sports bra and underwear.

Distraught and terrified, Adora was on the verge of a panic attack, “P-Please-! Stop, I don't-!” She gasped as she was suddenly flipped onto her stomach and held down, “Wh-What are you doing..?” She whined, tensing when one of the clones grabbed her ponytail. Her eyes widened when she heard the shears open again, “W-Wait! No!”

Cold, metal hands pressed on her back to keep her still as the blade sliced through her long hair.

Unable to move, and feeling all of her vulnerabilities being put on show, she began to cry. She wept as her hair was cut away until it rested against the top of her shoulders.

She didn't think it could get much worse.

Then she noticed a clone picking up a scalpel, while another picked up a small vial with something green inside.

The cold, empty air of the ship, her lack of clothing, and her fear of what was going to happen to her was making her body tremble. Her quiet whimpers turned to full on screams when what was left of her hair was pushed up and the scalpel suddenly cut into her neck.

She couldn't even attempt to fight, as all of her limbs and head were being harshly pressed against the metal table.

She felt small trails of blood run down the sides of her neck as something was pressed to the wound. She flinched and cried out when it felt like tweezers were suddenly clamped to the nerves in her neck.

The pain didn't show any signs of going away. It felt like her skin was fusing itself to the chip, the surrounding feeling a searing burn and sharp ache.

She whimpered as she was sat up, then pulled to her feet. She watched with distaste as the clones helped her into a white and gray bodysuit. The back was zipped up to the collar before that was covered by a hood that attached at the shoulders. She was sat back on the table as gray boots were slipped on her feet. Her breath hitched when she felt a comb be run through her hair, some sort of gel following to keep it in place.

“You are ready to join Prime's Empire.” One of the clones said with a calm smile.

Though shaking, Adora was able to muster a glare, "I w-will *never* -" She was cut off by a sudden blistering migraine. She gasped and grabbed her head. There was noise. So much noise.

So many sounds all at once, like the constant buzzing of bees working together in their hive.

Like…

A Hivemind.

She groaned when the sound only continued to get louder, drowning out any of her own thoughts. The only thing she could hear clearly was..

Welcome to the Light, little sister.

⚔

Etheria was much different than the last time any of them had been there.

Once they had arrived, the clones had left them on the edge of the Whispering Woods. The trio had immediately rushed into the

forest before checking themselves over for anything Prime could have planted on them to track their movements.

“What are we gonna do now?” Glimmer asked, leaning against a tree.

“I suggest we try to find the rest of the Rebellion. Maybe they're still at the camp?” Entrapta suggested.

“Probably the only thing we can do right now. Without Darla we aren't getting back to space and there's no way we're stealing one of his undetected.” Bow sighed, “Maybe Micah will know what to do.”

Glimmer perked up at that, “What..?”

Bow's eyes widened, “That's right, we never got to tell you… When Adora and I went to save Entrapta, we found your dad too.”

Tearing up, Glimmer looked at the ground, trying to process the information. She slowly nodded, “Let's go back to whatever camp you left from. Hopefully someone is still there.”

“Shouldn't be too hard! The clearing isn't too far from here. Hopefully one of the sorcerers will see us to let us in.” Entrapta

smiled, hurrying off with the others, hiding under the cover of the trees to conceal their movements.

~

The camp was closer than the trio had originally thought, only around a half hour's walk.

When they approached, Glimmer teleported them inside, more than grateful to be able to sense and use her magic again.

“Glimmer?!” Frosta exclaimed, rushing over and leaping into her arms.

Glimmer laughed, returning the embrace, “Hey Frosta!”

“I'm so happy you're back!! Oh, we should get your dad! I know he'll be glad to see you!” The ice princess jumped out of the queen's arms, grabbing her hand and dragging her back to the main tent where they'd been holding meetings. As they approached it was clear one was happening at that moment.

“...we don't know when they're going to get back and we can't just keep sitting here with targets on our backs!” Shadow Weaver crossed her arms, “We need to start considering using-”

"-Using *what,* Shadow Weaver?"

" *Glimmer* ?!" Everyone gaped at the sudden appearance.

Micah stared in shock, slowly approaching, "Wow you… You really aren't a little girl anymore, are you?"

Tearing up, Glimmer threw her arms around him, "I missed you, dad…"

"I missed you too, baby…" He wiped his eyes, holding his daughter close to him, not wanting to let her go ever again.

"What are we talking about here..?" Her ruler instincts were already kicking in, despite her desire to let her father hold and shield her from the world.

"Shadow Weaver is trying to get us to use the Heart's magic against the Horde." Mermista groaned, rolling her eyes.

"Because that went *so well* last time!" Glimmer glared, "Are you really that stupid?!"

"Uhm, actually, I have a new question.." Scorpia cleared her throat, raising her pincer, "Where is Adora?"

Bow, Glimmer, and Entrapta shared worried looks, “Right…” The queen sighed, “We have *a lot* to catch you up on.”

⚔

Catra screamed as she threw the chair at the forcefield again, to no avail, “Let me *out* !! Let her go, you sick *bastards* !!”

In the last few hours she'd spent alone in the holding cell, she'd managed to claw up at least some portion of each of the walls, and she'd assaulted the barrier locking her inside with the chair at least fifteen times.

She grabbed the chair again, preparing another attack on the door. Just as she hurled the furniture at the forcefield, it finally lowered, sending her arsenal right into the clone and pushing them back against the wall.

The way it growled at her made her more than confident it was Hordak. She couldn't help but smirk, “Whoops.”

“Prime would like to see you.”

“Unless he's going to show me Adora's okay he can fuck off.”

“It wasn't a request.” The clone grabbed her arm and forced her to walk down the hallway back to the main deck.

She fixed Prime with a glare, “*Where is she*?”

“That's why I summoned you. You wish to see that she's alright, I'm here to ease your concerns.”

Catra narrowed her eyes.

Rising from his throne, Prime turned just as Adora stepped out from behind the giant wall of monitors, a hood covering her head.

Catra only felt dread instead of relief, “Adora..?”

Slowly, Adora pushed the hood off her head, revealing glowing green eyes and an eerily calm smile, “Hello, Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

> Glimmer is not chipped for those of you wondering. I did consider doing it, but her hair is so short that it wouldn't really be hidden like it was with Spinnerella. Oh, and if it wasn't clear, the scene where Prime showed Glimmer Micah didn't happen since the camp hasn't been destroyed and he wouldn't know about their whereabouts.

As always I love hearing what you think so far and what you think will happen next!

Miscalculations

Chapter Summary

"You miscalculated."

Chapter Notes

CW// Blood

I believe I made it clear, but just in case, there's parts here where Prime is talking through Adora, and I put her dialogue in italics to give you a visual of when that's happening.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had to fight every fiber of her being not to start crying. She would not let Prime see he was getting to her if she could help it.

“You’ve always wanted to be with her, haven’t you?” She flinched when she realized Prime was talking to her, “Now you can be, under my guidance.”

That wasn’t tempting in the slightest, “Over my dead body.” She seethed.

Prime shrugged, “If that is what you wish.” He stepped down the stairs of his throne, “Perhaps she could change your mind. Let me know when you’re ready to cooperate… unless she does it for you.”

“Rot in hell!” She spat as the dictator left the room, flanked by two clones. She watched him leave until she heard the familiar sound of magic. Her ears perked up as she slowly turned around to see Adora now wielding a sword, but it wasn’t She-Ra’s. It had a black hilt with a green blade that was the same shade as her eyes, sparking with what looked like electricity, “A-Adora..?”

“This would have been a lot easier if you just listened, Catra.” Adora said, beginning to slowly approach, “But you never were that good at listening, were you?”

Tensing, Catra’s ears folded back as she took a few steps back, “Adora…” Her flat tone was even more unnerving than the weapon in the blonde’s hand. Adora had always been the most expressive person Catra knew- even more so than Scorpia. Maybe she just knew her too well, but to her Adora had always worn her heart on her sleeve. Seeing and hearing her be so stoic and neutral was- terrifying.

“Your life would have been so much easier if you learned to listen, you know. You could have saved Etheria a lot of trouble. We wouldn’t be here if you had listened that day.”

Thaymor.

Catra gasped, leaping out of the way when Adora suddenly swung her sword at her, “My existence seems to cause a lot of trouble.” She growled.

“I think that’s something you and Glimmer could agree on.” Adora rushed forward, grabbing Catra’s shoulder and shoving her to the floor.

The brunette groaned, rearing her legs back and kicking Adora away so she could get back to her feet. She refused to unsheathe her claws. She wouldn’t hurt Adora again, especially when she wasn’t even in control of herself.

“Adora- please-” She gasped when the sword managed to cut her arm when Adora swung again. She grabbed her arm, drops of blood slipping through her fingers, hissing and immediately pulling away. The wound was almost instantly cauterized by the electric trim of the blade.

“What’s the matter? Isn’t this what you wanted? You wanted the Rebellion to fall, you wanted to win.” Adora rammed her weapon again, Catra rushing out the way just in time to escape a stab to her abdomen.

“This is the last thing I wanted.” Catra furrowed her eyebrows, leaping onto Adora’s shoulders with the intention of tackling her from behind.

Then she saw the chip, and she remembered the ports on the back of the clone’s necks.

Before she could react though, Adora threw her off into the wall behind Prime’s throne, drawing a cry out of the magicat.

“Aren’t you tired of disappointing everyone Catra?”

Looking up, she saw Adora ascending the staircase. She scrambled to get to her feet, but only managed to sit up before Adora was over her.

“Aren’t you tired of trying?”

“Aren’t you tired of listening?” Catra countered, grabbing the sword and using it to pull herself up and swing around behind Adora. She bit back the burning pain in her hand caused by grabbing the blade, but it was mild compared to what she grew up feeling, “You’ve never done anything that wasn’t for someone else, be it the Horde or the Rebellion.” She took a deep breath before slamming her fist against the chip.

Adora cried out, stumbling back and sending both of them down the short staircase to the floor and the sword sliding across the floor. Catra grunted and looked up, eyes widening when she noticed terrified blue irises leaking through the green- just for a moment.

“Adora?”

Groaning, Adora looked at her, “C-Catra..?” She gasped, eyes flickering back to normal again, “Where..?”

Quickly scooting over to her, Catra gently cupped Adora's face, "Hey, Adora.. It's okay, it'll be okay, I promise."

"I- I'm sorry I don't- I don't want-" She screamed when electricity struck through her body from the chip, causing Catra's eyes to widen as she recoiled her hand, just as the green returned.

"Adora please listen to me it's-" She cut herself off when she noticed white pupils were now accompanying the green glazing over Adora's eyes.

" *Are you not tired of all of this, Catra* ?"

Catra narrowed her eyes as both of them got to their feet, "Prime."

" *All of this can stop now. The pain that Your Adora has caused you can all go away, and the two of you can be together. All you have to do is join my Light* ."

"Tempting," Catra replied sarcastically, "How about you go fuck yourself instead?!" She grabbed Adora's shoulders and shoved her down against the stairs, wincing at the cry Adora let out as the chip was further damaged.

“Are you okay?!” she asked on instinct, worried as Adora slowly got to her feet, clutching at her neck with her hand.

“I’m fine…” Adora asked, eyes normal, “It’s not like you haven’t hurt me before.” She finished, eyes green.

“Come on, Adora… you’ve spent your entire life listening to everyone else. Can’t you for once do something just for *you* ?”

Tears ran down Adora’s face as her eyes flashed back and forth between blue and green, “But…what I want… *doesn’t matter* .”

“That’s not true, Adora.” Catra grabbed both of the blonde’s hands, “You’re your own person. You don’t have to let anyone tell you what to do!”

It was clear Adora was actively fighting the chip now, “Catra… please…” She whimpered, eyes returning to normal.

“It’s okay, princess. I’m going to get you out of here, I-” A thought suddenly occurred, and Catra scrambled to get it out before the chip took over again, “Adora- where is the ship you came on?”

“It’s- it’s down the hall that way..” She shakily pointed in the direction of the ramp entrance, “Take a left and it.. leads you to what looks like a g-garage..”

Nodding, Catra took a deep breath, "I need you to trust me."

"C-Catra…" Adora gasped and stumbled back when the chip shocked her again, her eyes glowing green and the white pupils returning. Catra shrieked when Adora grabbed her and slung her towards the cliff of the platform. She was barely able to remain on her feet, grabbing the shoulder of Adora's hood when she grabbed her again.

"Adora *please* - don't! Snap out of it!"

" *You're pathetic, you know that* ?" Catra glared at those haunting white pupils, despite her body trembling now.

"Not as pathetic as you!"

" *Hm, disappointing. Some creatures are destined only for destruction* ."

"Adora!" Catra screamed as she was shoved off the platform. She saw Adora's horrified expression as her eyes returned to normal.

⚔

"We have to do *something* !" Glimmer had tears in her eyes as she paced the floor of the meeting tent, "We can't just sit here and hope they make it back!"

"What *can* we do?" Bow asked, "We don't have a way to leave the planet, Glimmer. Even if Entrapta built us a new one it would take- a very long time!"

"Not to mention we lack the materials to make an aircraft sustainable for space." Entrapta added.

"I *can't* just sit here! I can't just *wait* and *hope* that they both make it out of there I…" Glimmer slumped into Bow's arms as tears ran down her face.

Micah looked away from the map he had been studying, something occurring to him, "Didn't you say Catra tried to help you escape?"

"Yeah..?" Glimmer sniffed, looking up.

"How did she do that?"

"She brought me to this chamber that had a teleportation pad Prime uses to transfer clones here…" She lit up seconds later, realizing what her father was implying, "That's genius! We just

need to find where the teleporter here is and we can get back to the ship in minutes! Entrapta?”

“There’s a spire near here, if there’s one there I can find it.”

“Wait, you three just got back and you expect us to let you go back there?” Mermista raised an eyebrow.

“I’m the queen, and two of my people are trapped in the clutches of a monster that only got here because of me. I’m going.” Glimmer declared, “We’ll be back in a week or so. We can use this to get Darla back too, just in case.”

Entrapta gasped, “Well then what are we waiting for! Let’s go!”

Micah enveloped Glimmer into a hug before she could leave, “Please, be careful. All of you.”

“We will dad.” Glimmer promised, giving him a kiss on the cheek. “We actually need someone else to come too, someone will have to send us there from the console.”

“I’ll do it,” Micah said, “It’s getting late, now is the perfect time to do this if we want a lot of cover.”

Nodding, Glimmer looked to Bow and Entrapta, who were already on their feet and waiting to leave. Together, the four ducked out of the tent, hoping to use the darkness of the setting moon and cover of the Whispering Woods to hide them long enough to make their move.

~

"There it is…" Bow whispered, pointing to a small platform with an attached console next to the spire. It seemed to be vacant of clones for the moment, probably all marching on the nearby village or looking for their camp.

"Alright, let's go!" Glimmer quietly commanded as they rushed out of the woods and over to the platform. Micah watched with a proud, but sad expression as his daughter and her friends stepped onto the platform. He couldn't believe he was about to send his daughter back to the same place where that monster stood.

"Please, be careful baby."

"We will dad." Glimmer smiled, watching as he quickly typed in the codes, bringing the forcefield up. He took a deep breath, slowly letting it out as he slid his hand up on the console, activating the machine and watching as the three disappeared in the blink of an eye.

Seconds later he heard footsteps and rushed back into the woods, just barely avoiding detection by the approaching clones.

⚔

Adora almost immediately jumped down after Catra once she realized what she had done. The hard landing combined with another shock from the chip at her defiance had knocked her unconscious.

When she slowly came to, she groaned, looking around for Catra. She gasped when she saw the brunette curled up on the floor, bloody and unmoving, "Catra..!?" She tried to stand, only to groan and collapse. She was undeterred, however, and pulled herself with her arms over to the brunette, "Catra…?"

Only managing a soft groan, Catra remained deathly still in the blonde's arms.

I apologize for the needless waste, little sister. It did not have to be like this if you had gotten through to her.

Fury coursed through Adora's veins as she heard Prime's voice ringing through her head. No, she would not fail Catra again. She cradled Catra close to her, her forehead resting to the magicat's as she closed her eyes, tears running down her face, "I am *not* your sister." She growled under her breath. She didn't even realize she was glowing, *they* were glowing, that she had managed to

harness some of her power back until Catra started coughing violently. Adora's eyes snapped open and she looked down at the brunette in her arms, "Catra?!"

"H-Hey, Adora.." Catra smiled, her exhaustion clear on her face.

Laughing tearfully, Adora hugged Catra again, relief washing over her when the embrace was returned.

"Catra? Adora?!"

The two gasped and looked up as Glimmer and Bow rushed up to them, "Glimmer..!?" They breathed together.

Glimmer and Bow were horrified at the scene before them, but knew they needed to escape before asking questions, "Come on, we need to get out of here."

Bow helped Adora to her feet while Glimmer helped Catra.

"How did you guys get here..?" Catra asked, wincing as they started to make their way towards the nearest hallway as fast as possible.

“Same way you tried to get me out the first time.” Glimmer chuckled, gasping when a group of clones blocked the doorway.

Bow pressed the earpiece he had with his free hand, “Entrapta, we’re below the platform where we were brought the first time. We need you, *now* !”

“Give me a few seconds!” Entrapta replied. Bow heard her maniacal laughter in his ear seconds before the doorway exploded, and all the clones were crushed as Entrapta landed Darla on the clones blocking their way. Glimmer and Bow helped Catra and Adora up the ramp as soon as it lowered.

Once everyone was safely aboard, the scientist wasted no time speeding through the mother ship, destroying everything in her path until she blasted through into space and back towards Etheria.

⚔

Adora had pulled Catra into a hug as soon as they were safe on the floor of Darla’s main deck, “I’m so sorry- I didn’t mean-”

“Shh..” Catra lightly bumped her forehead to Adora’s, “It wasn’t your fault.”

“Can.. can I ask what happened..?”

“He chipped her..” Catra replied, “Which we need to get rid of. He can track us otherwise I’m sure.”

Entrapta turned her attention from the console, “Chip?”

Adora shakily nodded, not wanting to elaborate further.

“Bow, can you take over for me while I take a look?”

“Sure thing.” The archer nodded, making his way over to the main controls while Entrapta walked behind Adora to examine the chip, grabbing a few tools with her hair from a box behind the pilot’s chair.

Catra gently took Adora’s hands, offering a warm smile of support.

Carefully, Entrapta removed the cover of the chip. Glimmer bit back a gasp at the cluster of wires that was revealed.

“Is it bad..?” Adora whispered, worry glazing her eyes.

“No! It’s just very interesting!” Entrapta assured in her own way as she started picking at the wires with a pair of tweezers, “It’s like the chip is trying to fuse with your nervous system! It’s so *fascinating* !”

“ *Entrapta* ..” Catra hissed, dragging the princess back to attention.

“Sorry!” Blushing lightly, Entrapta returned her attention to the task at hand, “Let’s see here…” She stuck her tongue out in concentration as she looked for the main connectors between the chip and Adora, “Glimmer could you grab some gauze and a bandage? I don’t know if she’s going to bleed when I take it off.”

Nodding, the queen hurried to find a first aid kit.

Adora whimpered when she felt the tweezers pull on the main wire, the sound of a small torch vibrating against it.

“It’s okay..” Catra whispered, running her thumb over the back of Adora’s hand.

“Alright.. Just a little more and… aha!” Entrapta smiled triumphantly as she sliced through the wire, severing the connection, and parasitic relationship in the process. Blood did start to run down Adora’s neck when the chip was pulled out. Luckily, Glimmer returned with the first aid kit, quickly dabbing up the blood with some gauze before covering it with a bandage.

“There you go…” Glimmer smiled sadly when she stepped back.

“With the chip removed from its power source Prime will no longer be able to track us!” Entrapta explained as she dropped the chip into a test tube.

“Now, you two both need some serious rest.” Glimmer said, “It’ll take us a few days to get back to Etheria, so take the time to relax and… try and heal as much as possible.”

Nodding, Catra got to her feet alongside Adora, the two helping each other out of the room and down the hall to the nearest bedroom.

Chapter End Notes

I promise there will be some fluff next chapter! I know this one was rough like the last one, lol. I have a really adorable scene between Glimmer and Catra that I can't wait to share!

I love hearing what you think of the AU so far and what you think will happen next! <3

A Course for Home

Chapter Summary

> Catra is doing everything she can to prove herself to the Rebellion, but more importantly, she wants to make sure that Adora is okay.

Chapter Notes

> I swear to god I am going to finish at least one of my chapter fics this year! I'm so sorry for the long wait, but I hope you enjoy the chapter!

Catra took a deep breath, watching Adora as she slept. The blonde had passed out almost immediately after they got into the room. It made her happy that Adora was getting much needed, and deserved, sleep, but she was still in that cursed bodysuit. She knew the moment Adora woke up she would panic. Biting her lip, the brunette stood, walking over to a chest in the corner. She grabbed a tank top and sweats out of it, before making her way back. She sat the clothes down at the end of the bed before returning to her place at Adora's side.

Her place.

She took another deep breath to will herself not to start crying. Again. She knew she wanted to be at Adora's side, she'd known that for a very long time. She only wished she'd been brave enough to take that step sooner. Maybe Adora wouldn't have been tortured.

We wouldn't be here if you had listened that day.

Inhaling sharply, she ran her fingers through her hair, squeezing her eyes closed. Why did Adora care about her still? After everything she'd done? She couldn't even do one good thing in her life! Prime made sure she failed even that.

Aren't you tired of disappointing everyone, Catra?

Tears ran down her face. She sniffed, quickly wiping her eyes and hugging her legs. She knew she was a failure. She'd always known, but this felt like the worst crime she'd committed yet. She tried to help, and it got Adora hurt. Worse than hurt- almost killed.

Slowly, quietly, she leaned over and kissed Adora's forehead, before getting up and making her way out of the room. Once the door slid closed behind her she made her way back towards the main deck of the ship.

She wasn't surprised Entrapta was still up there, tinkering with the ship -Darla- and humming quietly to herself.

"...Entrapta?"

Flinching, the princess turned, smiling and waving at her, "Hey, Catra! Is Adora doing okay? I've been studying the chip's code

and it's- pretty complicated. Luckily, it wasn't on her very long, or it could have caused much more damage!"

"How did you do it?"

"Do what? Study the chip? Easy! I just plugged the coding into my trackerpad and then-"

"-Not... that. The others the.. Rebellion. How did you get them to accept you?"

Oh. This was an emotional conversation. Entrapta stood there for a moment, blinking a few times as she processed, before setting her tablet down and turning to give the magicat her full attention, "Well, sometimes I think they still don't. Not fully. I still mess up, make mistakes because- I don't understand the social context and cues like they do. I try my best to help through tech, because that's what I do best, but that isn't always enough. I think, I think what you're best at isn't always enough, or right, but as long as you never give up, and keep trying- show that you want to do better to... be better, you'll be okay. I think… I think it also just takes time."

Catra's ears pinned, her tail wrapped around her leg, "I don't know what I would even be able to offer."

Entrapta smiled slightly, stepping a little closer. Only slightly though. Then she gently touched her hand over Catra's chest,

right over her heart. Catra's ears perked up, "You have a lot more than you think."

Finally, Catra cracked a smile, "Thanks... You- You're a good friend, Entrapta."

"You're welcome!" Entrapta bounced on her feet, stepping back.

"Entrapta?" Catra repeated when she realized she was going back to work.

"Yes?" Entrapta turned back to glance at her.

"I... I'm sorry."

Smiling, Entrapta nodded, her hair giving her a gentle pat on the head, "I forgive you."

A small smile formed of her own, and Catra nodded, before she turned and started back down the hallway, quietly laughing when she heard the scientist start babbling into her recorder about 'an exciting social development'.

As she drew closer to Adora's room, she picked up on muttering, the familiar, anxiety induced doubts that had plagued her for as

long as Catra could remember. She took off, running as fast as she could to the door and tapping the button repeatedly until it opened.

"Adora? Adora!" She gasped when she saw the blonde curled up in the fetal position, muttering apologies through her ragged breathing.

"I- I I'm sorry- I'm so sorry I didn't mean to-"

"Adora!" Catra grabbed the blonde's hands as soon as she was close enough, pulling them away from the sides of her head, "Stop that! You don't need to pull more hair out."

Whining, Adora tried to free her wrists, panicked cries following when she couldn't.

"Adora- promise me you won't try to hurt yourself anymore, and I'll let you go."

"W-Why?! I failed! I failed to save everyone I- I lost! Just leave me alone! I- I deserve to-"

"Stop!" Catra finally snapped, "If you finish that sentence I *swear."* She hoisted Adora up by her wrists, sitting down as she pulled the blonde into her arms, *"Look at me."*

Adora slowly looked up at her, her expression meek, her eyes glossy and body trembling as she curled up in her arms. She looked so small.

"What happened wasn't your fault, Adora. We all did our best, but Prime is unlike anything any of us have ever had to deal with. He took us all by surprise, but we're away from him and safe, for now. None of us hate you, we all care about you and want to help you heal and get better."

Nodding, Adora sniffed, "I- I'm-"

"Shh..."

The pair stayed silent for a while, neither sure how long, before Adora broke the silence, "Catra..?"

"Mhm?"

"Can you take off this uniform? Please? *Please*- I, I need it gone...!"

"Of course, princess." Catra gently sat her down on the bed before turning her to see her back, "Let's get you into something more comfortable."

Catra made quick work of the uniform, unzipping the back before helping Adora quickly wiggle out of it. She planned to chuck the thing out of the airlock as soon as she got the chance. Once Adora was comfortable in her sweats and tank top, she returned to Catra's lap, hugging her tight and resting her head on her shoulder, "Catra…?"

Still processing, Catra shook herself out of her trance, fighting not to blush as she wrapped her arms around Adora, "Yes…?"

"My… my hair… I hate it. I hate it!"

Catra's ears folded back, "I know… I'm so sorry that happened to you, Adora…" She felt herself tearing up again, "I wish I could fix it… I know how much you love your long hair…"

Whining, Adora tightened her grip on Catra's shoulders, "I tried so hard to stop them… but- but I don't have She-Ra anymore."

That took Catra by surprise, "Wait- what?"

"I destroyed my sword… I had to when the planet was balanced.. If I hadn't…"

"..Then the Heart would have gone off. Oh- I'm…" Catra just hugged her a little closer.

"I should have known I'd fail against him. I- I'm not her anymore, I'm not a hero I-"

"Whoa whoa whoa!" Catra gripped the blonde's arms and moved her so their gazes met, "Adora, you never needed She-Ra to be a hero. She may have helped, but you are amazing and strong and powerful all on your own."

"Doesn't feel like it…"

"You protected our squad as kids. I know you could only do so much. We were kids. But you protected us. You- You protected me. " Catra's ears pinned again, "Adora I… I'm so sorry, for everything. I should have listened, and because of me… I'm sorry. I'll do everything I can to make it up to you and- and if you ever want me to go.. I'll go-" She flinched when Adora hugged her again.

"I never want you anywhere else that isn't with me. I don't want to be anywhere that isn't with you. I've missed you so much Catra. And, I'm sorry too."

Smiling, Catra returned the embrace. She hadn't felt this safe, this at home in a very, very long time.

⚔

Catra wasn’t sure how long they sat in the hug, but when she pulled away, Adora had been fast asleep. As carefully as she could, Catra had laid her back down on the bed and covered her up, before once again slipping out of the room. She had different plans this time though. Making her way into the bathroom, she caught a glimpse of her reflection in the mirror, biting her lip as she stared at herself. She grabbed some of her hair around the same time she noticed a pair of scissors on the counter.

She'd always loved her hair. It made her feel bigger than she actually was. It was like a shield, a mask she could use to her advantage. But... she knew how much Adora loved her hair too, and how vulnerable she was feeling losing most of it after it was forcibly cut. She wanted to make her feel a little better, in any way she could.

Slowly, she reached for the scissors, but her trembling hand stopped her from picking them up. Groaning, she turned and left the bathroom, grateful Glimmer happened to be heading down the hallway, "Sparkles..?"

"Oh, hey Catra. Is everything alright? Is Adora..?"

"She's- asleep, but that's not... I need a favor." Her ears folded back, her tail wrapping around her leg, “If- that’s okay…”

"What is it?" Glimmer raised an eyebrow, "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, yeah.. I just- I need you to do something I can't do myself."

Though she was confused, whatever it was clearly was extremely important to the brunette, "Of course, how can I help?" She softly asked.

"I..." The brunette looked down, "I need you to cut my hair."

That definitely wasn't what she expected, "Oh? Why do you..."

Glimmer thought about it for a moment. Then it hit her.

A sad yet warm smile formed on the queen's face. She gently placed a hand on Catra's shoulder to prompt eye contact, "She's really going to appreciate that. Come on." She gently followed the magicat into the bathroom, pushing the door closed behind them.

Catra slowly sat down on the toilet seat, her anxiety spiking when Glimmer picked up the scissors and approached, "How short do you want it?"

"My shoulders.. like hers."

Noticing how nervous she was, Glimmer crouched in front of her, taking her hand, "This is a really brave and thoughtful decision. I think this will help her a lot, but remember this is your choice too, okay?"

Nodding, Catra closed her eyes as Glimmer stood, returning to stand behind her, before slowly beginning to cut her hair.

It only took a few minutes to make the the initial cuts, chopping the bulk of Catra's hair to get it to the length she requested, she started making smaller cuts to style it and give it a few layers. Glimmer smiled. She hoped Catra would like it, she certainly did.

When she put down the scissors and picked up a comb, she couldn't help but notice how... small, Catra looked now. She was somehow so much less threatening. Not that she had felt like a threat to Glimmer in quite some time now.

"How bad is it..?" Catra mumbled, still refusing to open her eyes.

"Not at all." Glimmer assured, helping Catra up and stepping over to the mirror with her, "You can look now."

After taking a deep breath, she opened her eyes and gasped. She actually... loved it! "Wow..." She smiled, running her fingers

through her hair. It felt so light yet looked so voluminous, "Do all princesses just know how to cut hair?"

Glimmer giggled, "No, I just taught myself when I cut my own. I used to have really long hair too, and I was not a fan."

"Well- in any case, thank you." She smiled, pulling the queen into a hug.

"You're welcome. You can go check on her if you want. I'll clean up."

Nodding, Catra gave her one more quick hug before slipping out of the room. She took a deep breath, running her fingers through the short layers. It felt so light! She knew it was slightly longer than Adora's, she was able to pull her hair back enough to make a baby ponytail, but Adora's hair wasn't layered. She made a mental note to ask Adora if she wanted to try styling her hair later. At least make herself feel a little better about the condition Prime had forced on her.

She approached the room, sighing as she quietly stepped inside. She grabbed shorts and a crop top out of Adora's chest. It looked

almost identical to their Horde issued pajamas, just without the symbol. She changed before laying down next to the blonde, who immediately snuggled up to her. She felt herself falling asleep faster than she ever had, at least, in the time since Adora left. She welcomed the changed, wrapping her arms and tail around her oldest friend as she quickly drifted off to sleep.

⚔

Adora groaned as she slowly woke up. She felt momentary panic when she couldn't find Catra. Had she dreamt she was there? She sat up, relief flooding her when the door opened and the brunette walked into the room, "There you are, I thought-" Her eyes widened when she saw her friend's hair, "Catra… what did you…?"

Catra blushed, remembering the night before, "Right, I- uh, I wanted you to feel less alone about it," She explained as she approached the bed, "So I asked Sparkles to cut it for me so- so we can grow it out together. Surprise?"

Tears ran down Adora's face as she leapt out of bed and into Catra's arms, "This is the sweetest thing anyone h-has ever done for me…!" She sniffed, "Thank you…!"

"You're welcome, princess." Catra smiled.

As she composed herself, Adora took in the new look, smiling, "It suits you… you look beautiful…" She practically whispered,

running her fingers through the layers, “I love it.”

It took the two a few minutes to part and get dressed, before making their way to the main deck together, where Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta were sitting around a silver tray, “What’s this?” Adora asked as she and Catra sat down.

“Steamed buns. My mom used to make these with me, and she wasn’t that good a cook either,” Glimmer giggled, “Figured it would be hard to mess up.”

Adora’s eyes widened when she took a bite of one handed to her, “Wow, Glimmer! This is delicious!”

Catra smiled as she took a bit of her own, “Prime should have asked you to help with dinner, Sparkles. This is so much better than that jello shit he gave us.”

Snorting, Glimmer smiled, “Oh jeez, that stuff was awful wasn’t it.” She chuckled, “Thank you.”

The group ate for a while, making small talk while Darla cruised through space back towards Etheria.

“So,” Bow started, taking the last bite of his food, “Entrapta and I checked our fuel load this morning, and we’re running on empty, so we have to make a little detour before going home.”

“We need crystals called Thulite!” Entrapta added with a chirp, “Luckily, I found a nearby planet called Krytis that has some! We should be there in an hour or so!”

“How long will it take for us to get home after that?” Catra asked.

The scientist shrugged, “If everything goes smoothly I’d say no more than a week, give or take, but it’s only a few more days before we’ll be able to make contact with the rest of the Rebellion on Etheria.”

“I hope they’re all alright…” Glimmer frowned, her mind drifting back to her father.

Bow set a hand on her shoulder, “Your dad is gonna be alright, Glimmer. I’m sure he’s keeping the camp safe.”

“Yeah… yeah, you’re probably right.” Glimmer took a deep breath, a small smile forming.

“We need to figure out what we’re gonna do once we actually get back.” Adora hummed, the anxiety in her head quickly expanding to take over the rest of her thoughts, “We still don’t know anything that could be Prime’s weakness. We can’t fight him if as far as we know he’s invincible.”

“Everyone has a weakness, Adora.” Catra assured, taking her hand and giving it a gentle squeeze, “We just have to look for it.”

“Tch, it’s probably his vanity.” Glimmer rolled her eyes, “And his ego. And his mouth. He does not know when to shut up.”

“Got *that* right.” Catra scoffed.

“Well, whatever it is, we need to find it soon.” Adora muttered.

“Maybe the others back on Etheria have had some luck. Prime said that he fought the First One’s, so maybe there’s something written somewhere about it.” Glimmer suggested, looking to Bow.

“You’re right..! When we get back I need to find my dads. If anyone would have any information about it, it would be them. Actually, Castaspella and Micah may too. Mystacor has lots of stories about the First One’s.”

“You’re right! Okay, that’s good. If we don’t find anything before we get home, hopefully the others have.”

⚔

Everyone carefully adjusted their spacesuits as Darla landed on Krytis, making sure everything was secure and safe before the airlock opened. The moment they stepped off of the ramp, they were faced with what clearly used to be one of Prime's spires, "Of course he was here too…" Catra muttered.

"Well, there has to be a log of the invasion. Maybe I can find out what!" Entrapta grabbed her tablet, using her hair to leap over the debris and down to the bottom of the spire, "Let's see here… aha!" The scientist giggled with glee as she plugged her tablet into the spire, quickly starting the download of the invasion as well as any information Prime had stored, "Oh perfect, the schematics are already downloaded. Let's see…" After glancing through the map, she tilted her head, "Oh! I'm picking up a heat signature! There's someone alive on this planet still!"

"Maybe they'll know where the Thulite crystals are!" Glimmer smiled, clasping her hands together.

"You seriously think it's a good idea to just approach a random person and hope they'll tell us what we need to know?" Catra raised an eyebrow, crossing her arms.

"Well, it's either that or we wander an entire planet until we find them." Glimmer fired back. Catra sighed.

"Whatever." She hummed, catching the earpiece Entrapta tossed to her.

“I’ll guide you all through! Hopefully, if you don’t find the heat signature quickly, maybe the logs will have information about the Thulite!”

Adora put the earpiece in, taking a deep breath as she made her way up the ramp into an old building near the spire, the others a few steps behind.

“Everything okay..?” Catra quietly asked as she quickened her pace to be next to the blonde.

Nodding, Adora kept her gaze forward, trying her best to focus on the mission, “I’m fine.”

“Adora…”

“I’m fine, I promise..!” Adora smiled, but it didn’t reach her eyes, “We need to find this fuel, and get back to Etheria. We need to stop Prime before he hurts anyone else.”

She let it go for now, but once they were back on the ship, she would be checking in with her.

“Once you get to the end of that hallway, there should be a door on your left leading up.” Entrapta chimed in over the earpiece.

“Copy that.” Adora replied, straightening her posture.

Bow noticed Glimmer looking around and placed a hand on her shoulder, “Hey. You okay?”

“Yeah, just- something feels weird about this place. I don’t know what it is…”

“Huh.”

As the group made their way up to the next floor, the creaking sound of metal was heard overhead somewhere as they walked. It was eerily quiet. It made Catra’s tail fluff up and Adora look around at any creak or noise in the distance, “This place gives me the creeps.” Catra commented after a while, pausing when the group came upon a seemingly dead end.

“Why’d you stop? Go through the door!”

“There isn’t a door here.” Adora answered, looking around for any sign of a handle or password or scanner.

“Hate to disagree, but the schematics are showing a door right in front of you.”

“Here, I’ll handle it.” Catra huffed, stepping forward and unsheathing her claws to their full extent and slicing through the wall in front of them, creating a square opening for them to walk through, “There’s your door. You’re welcome.”

“Uhm, we don’t entirely know what we’re dealing with here, maybe you shouldn’t just smash stuff…” Bow squeaked.

“Do you want to get anything done here or not?” Catra asked, stepping through the doorway and offering her hand to Adora, who gently took it as she stepped through as well.

“Whoa…” Adora gasped, looking around at the giant room they found themselves in. It looked like it could have been a foyer once, or a grand hall. Strange green plant was growing up the walls. It looked kind of like algae, and like it was eating away at the spire and walls around them.

“I’m detecting the heat signature on the hallway to your left.”

The group looked, everyone tensing at the sight of what looked to be a very, very long hallway.

“Seriously..?” Catra sighed, “Are we really doing this..?”

“Well, Entrapta says this is the way, so…” Adora took the first steps into the hall, but she was clearly on edge herself.

~

They had been walking for nearly thirty minutes, and the end of the hallway was getting no closer, no matter how long they walked, “This is impossible!” Catra groaned, “This place is weird! And Unnatural!”

“Adora! Are you there? I downloaded the rest of the records from Prime's occupation of Krytis, and guess what?! This planet was once a First Ones colony like Etheria. It looks like Horde Prime and the First Ones were fighting for control of this planet, and Horde Prime won. But something on the planet drove him away before he could conquer it. He tried to erase all records of his failure.”

“So- we’re on the right path?” Adora asked, a hopeful smile forming on her face.

“But we have to get out of here first. And that door still isn't getting any closer.” Bow frowned, crossing his arms.

“Sorry- what door?”

“What do you mean what door?” Catra furrowed her eyebrows, “The one you told us to go through!”

“That wasn’t me, this is the last time we’ve talked since the last floor.”

“Wait what?” Adora’s eyes widened, tears welling up in her eyes, “This was a terrible plan wasn’t it? Please don’t be another Prime mind trick I can’t- I-”

“Whoa, whoa, Adora it’s okay..” Catra quickly wrapped her arms around the blonde, holding her in a gently hug, “Prime isn’t here. I promise.”

Nodding shakily, Adora sniffed, “Okay…”

“By the way! Who’s your new friend?”

“W-What are you talking about?” Glimmer asked as she pressed the button on her earpiece, “It’s just the four of us.”

“Hate to disagree, but there's a definite heat signature, right behind you.”

Slowly, the four turned, dread and fear overcoming them when they were met with a humanoid figure with a blue mane, its head cocked to one side. Everyone screams right before Catra shoves herself between Glimmer and Bow and tackled the creature. It’s magic surrounded them both before they teleported.

“Catra! Catra!!” The brunette heard in her earpiece the moment she landed. She groaned, sitting up with a gasp when the figure towered over her.

“Adora! I’m under the ramp below the main room!” Catra began trembling as the creature loomed over her, transforming into a feline-looking animal, roaring at her angrily.

“I’m coming!”

“Hurry…”

The trio raced back down towards the main deck, being forced to stop suddenly when spikes shoot out of the wall, narrowly missing her neck as she froze.

“Adora- What do we do..?” Bow asked through gritted teeth as he fought not to move.

“I-I don’t know! I- I can’t- I…!” Tears ran down the blonde’s face. All she could think of was the scalpel that had cut her neck and implanted the chip in her. She struggled not to move as her body trembled.

Glimmer stared at the spikes, skeptical as she moved her finger, watching the supposed pieces of metal twist and bend around her.

"Glimmer! What are you doing?" Bow asked anxiously with wide eyes.

"Hold on, I need to try something." Slowly, she pressed her finger against one of the spikes, smiling when it evaporated into spores of magical energy, "Illusions! These are illusions! Which means-" The queen gathered the spores in her hand before drawing a rune in the air and pushing it forward, dispensing the spikes and showing they were at the start of the hallway, "I knew I felt something about this place! It's magic!"

Bow smiled, but it faded immediately when he saw Adora still frozen in place, "Adora..!" He placed a hand on her shoulder, and she screamed and jerked away, "Adora, you're safe. Prime isn't here."

Taking a few deep breaths, Adora nodded.

"Adora… it's gonna be alright. He can't hurt you anymore." Glimmer assured, smiling sadly at her.

"I-I know I just.."

The three jumped when they heard the creature roar angrily in the distance. It seemed to jump start something in Adora.

"Catra!"

The brunette in question was tense, watching with her eyes as the feline walked around her, its mane bright red. It turned invisible for a moment, before reappearing nose-to-nose with Catra, who whimpered, before sneezing. Seeming almost stunned, the creature sat down in front of her, before mimicking her sneeze perfectly and starting to purr.

Tilting her head, Catra blinked, reaching her hand out towards it just as the others fall out of a rune Glimmer had drawn, landing near them, "Catra hold— on?" Adora raised an eyebrow as she realized Catra was now petting the thing that had just been trying to kill them, "Who's this..?"

Shrugging, Catra continued to gently pet its head, "I think it responds to emotions, I'm just- trying something." She muttered, doing her best to ignore the quiet cooing and snickers from Bow and Glimmer. Her eyes widened when the feline started to glow, magical energy surrounding them both before fading away like nothing had happened.

"What was *that?"* Glimmer asked, bewildered.

“Uhm, I don’t- I…” Catra gasped when it suddenly started talking to her, “Guys? Can you here it talking? Please tell me you can hear it talking?”

The others shook their heads, and the brunette turned her attention back to them, “It must have imprinted on you.” Bow shrugged, “It- trusts you.”

“Why is everything with you guys so weird?!” She took a deep breath, zoning her attention in on them so she could translate, “They say their name is Melog. They’ve- been here alone for a really long time. They thought we were enemies, like- like the- the ones who came to take their magic?” She raised an eyebrow.

“The First Ones…” Adora breathed.

“They dug into the ground, built machines.”

“They dug into the ground, built machines, but- but they took too much. And then- then ‘the one who destroys’ came.”

Catra and Adora’s eyes widened with fear when Melog shifted to look like Horde Prime.

“He- He tried to conquer this place, but couldn’t. The magic of Krytis was too wild for Prime. He didn’t- understand what it was.

He couldn’t use it, or defend against it… Melog drove Prime off, but couldn’t defeat him. And now… they’re the last of their kind.”

“Magic… magic is Prime’s weakness!!” Glimmer gasped, suddenly excited.

Once Melog shifted back to a feline, Adora felt safe enough to approach, “I’m sorry for what happened to you, but we’re gonna make sure it never happens to anyone else. Our planet has magic too, it could be the last place in the universe that does.”

Mewling, Melog licked her face, making her laugh.

“That solves that issue. Now we just need- oh!” Catra turned to Melog, “Do you know where these pink Thulite crystals are here? We kinda need a few to fuel our ship home. If you don’t mind…”

Meowing again, Melog hopped up, starting down the pathway towards what looked like a cavern entrance.

“Entrapta? We think we found the crystals! And we’ve got a new friend.” Adora reported as they started following the feline.

“That’s great! Once you get them, get back to the ship and we can blast off!”

⚔

"Okay, we should be able to reach the Rebellion in just a few minutes." Entrapta said, mostly to herself as she fidgeted with her trackerpad.

"I hope they're all okay…" Adora sighed, leaning against Catra.

"Me too…" Glimmer frowned. She really hoped her dad was alright. He was strong, she knew he could handle himself. But she felt like Prime had a vendetta against her after their 'talk'.

"Oh! I got it!" Entrapta called, everyone quickly gathering around the tablet as Perfuma answered the comm.

"Adora! Entrapta! Oh thank goodness you're all alright! Please tell me you're on the way back?"

"Yeah, we should be there soon. Is everything okay? Is everyone safe?" Glimmer asked.

"Well… we've been ambushed a few times. A lot of us have been-chipped."

Adora gasped, grabbing Catra's arm, "No…"

“Who?” Bow furrowed his eyebrows.

“Castaspella, Scorpia, Mermista, Spinnerella- the rest of us are just hiding in the woods. We don’t know what else to do!”

“We’ll be back soon!” The queen assured.

“You need to be careful.” Netossa intervened, sitting next to the blonde, “The Horde has a blockade set up around the planet.”

Catra looked down at Melog, before smiling, “Don’t worry, we got that covered.”

“Catra?! What are you-”

“She’s with us now!” Glimmer and Adora chimed at the same time and making the magicat blush.

“We’ll be home soon, I promise. We’ll meet you in the woods.” Adora finished before ending the call, “Melog? Do you think you can shield us?”

Mewling, Melog purred.

“They’ll protect us.” Catra translated with a small smile.

“Everyone get ready then, we have a little bit of time before we get back, but we need to make sure the blockade doesn’t see us.” Entrapta explained. Everyone started preparing themselves and the ship anyway they could.

They were going home. Prime wouldn’t stop them this time.

Fight for the Frightzone

Chapter Summary

> Slowly, everyone returned to the table and gathered around, some standing and some sitting at the few seats that were available. Catra made sure to sit next to Glimmer, and Adora was standing on her other side.
>
> "How do you know she's in the Frightzone?" Adora asked.
>
> "We've been tracking the princesses with one of Bow's trackerpads," Perfuma explained.
>
> "After she caused some chaos in a village along the coast she retreated to the Frightzone." Micah explained, pointing on the map, "Spinnerella and Mermista followed her from different villages soon after."

Chapter Notes

> Ahh it feels so good to be updating my WIPs again. I realize that the rest of this fic is technically a rewrite of season 5's final episodes, but I'm taking a different route and changing things up. Originally, there was going to be 9 chapters, but this chapter and the next would have wound up being short, so I decided to combine them so the next chapter will be about the Failsafe, and then the finale. I have big plans on how to rewrite and change the story so it isn't repetitive, so stick around! <3
>
> CW// Panic Attack

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Being back on Etheria was almost foreign to the squad. They slowly stepped off the ramp into the woods, glancing around, "It feels so good to be home…" Glimmer sighed, smiling and taking a deep breath as she felt her magic returning, "I can't wait to find

everyone! Ooh! The camp it a bit of a walk from here sooo…" She giggled, grabbing everyone and teleporting the five minute walk to the edge of their camp.

Catra groaned as soon as they appeared, stumbling forward. Adora quickly caught her, frowning, "Are you alright?"

"Y-Yeah.."

"I missed that so much!"

"Really? Because I could stand to never do it again." Catra took a deep breath, hand over her stomach.

"Sorry- I'll try to give a warning next time?" The queen apologized, a nervous smile on her face.

"That would be nice, thank you." Catra smiled, feeling less light-headed the longer she stood there.

"Who's out here- Glimmer!"

The group turned, relieved when it was just King Micah. Glimmer rushed into his arms, "Dad!"

“I’m so glad you’re all okay. You couldn’t have gotten back at a better time.”

“What’s going on?” Adora furrowed her eyebrows, “Is everyone okay?”

Micah sighed, quickly guiding the group into the camp so they would remain hidden, “Several of our people have been chipped. We aren’t entirely sure how it happened, but we had to hide- the bots and clones won’t stop coming and we just- we don’t know what to do.”

Adora stiffened at the mention of more people being chipped. She imagined they hadn’t been put through the same process she’d been through. She hoped they hadn’t. Her hand slowly rose to the back of her neck, her body tense.

Catra gently placed a hand on Adora’s shoulder, smiling at her, “It’s okay…” She whispered, “Who’s all… chipped?”

“Scorpia, Spinnerella, Mermista, and- Castaspella.” Micah frowns. Glimmer’s breath hitched at the news.

Catra glanced around the camp at the remaining rebels, trying to remember everyone’s names. The flower girl was Perfuma, the kid was Frosta, Netossa, Micah, Sea shanty? No- Sea Hawk? They

were all standing around a table when they finally noticed the others.

"Glimmer!" Frosta exclaimed, racing over and leaping into the queen's waiting arms.

"Frosta!"

"Bow!"

Catra tensed, taking a few steps back as the group reunited.

"Oh I'm so glad you all made it back safe!" Perfuma exclaimed, still hugging Bow even as Netossa tried to pull her off of him.

Frosta was the first to notice Catra, her eyes widening, "Horde Scum!" she glared, Catra's breath hitching as ice armor forming around the princess' hands, but Glimmer quickly held her back, "Whoa whoa whoa. She's with us now."

"She is…?" Frosta looked very unenthused.

Glimmer nodded, and the ice armor slowly faded away, "So, what are we planning?"

Perfuma perked up at that, grabbing a Scorpia action figure off of the table, "We found Scorpia has returned to the Frightzone, and we were hoping to find a way to free her from the chip."

Slowly, everyone returned to the table and gathered around, some standing and some sitting at the few seats that were available. Catra made sure to sit next to Glimmer, and Adora was standing on her other side.

"How do you know she's in the Frightzone?" Adora asked.

"We've been tracking the princesses with one of Bow's trackerpads," Perfuma explained.

"After she caused some chaos in a village along the coast she retreated to the Frightzone." Micah explained, pointing on the map, "Spinnerella and Mermista followed her from different villages soon after."

"Well… if Scorpia went back to the Frightzone, then part of her must recognize it as home. That has to mean something!" Perfuma smiled, a small flower crown forming around the mini Scorpia.

"That pile of junk isn't a home to anyone." Catra grumbled.

Perfuma narrowed her eyes, “Scorpia saved me. She stayed behind so we could escape the Enchanted Grotto. If there’s anyone who could resist Horde Prime’s programming- It’s Scorpia! Her heart’s too strong!”

“Well, she also isn’t great at standing up to authority figures.” Catra rebuttaled.

“Your negative vibes aren’t appreciated here, Catra.” Perfuma huffed.

Catra rolled her eyes, “Look, what matters is destroying the chip. Going for the back of the neck is how we take out Prime’s clones. That’s how I got through to Adora, because the chip got damaged first.” Adora gently hugged herself, tensing at the memories.

“What you think you know how to save Scorpia better than I do?” Perfuma glared, “I know all about how you treated her back in the Horde.” Catra’s eyes widened at that, “Things are different now. Scorpia knows the kindness of a true friend-!”

“Hey!” Glimmer glared, her hand resting on Catra’s back, “You’re right, things are different, and Catra is a lot different from how she was back then. We’ve all done things we regret, but right now isn’t the time to dwell on them.”

“Exactly, and we all want to save Scorpia. But to do that we have to work together. If it weren’t for Catra, I wouldn’t be here. So,

let’s just focus on the plan in front of us.” Adora added. Catra couldn’t help but smile slightly, but her ears remained folded back, “So, we’ll need Melog to cloak us on our way in, I know a way through the desert we can use to get into the Frightzone. If we use the map on- Bow? Bow.”

“Huh?” the archer looked up from his trackerpad.

“Is everything okay? You’re kinda- spaced out.” Glimmer frowns.

“Sorry I just..” He sighed, “I haven’t been able to contact my dads lately and I just- I’m worried. I know the library is well hidden but…”

“We should go check on them.” Glimmer says, getting to her feet.

“But this mission-”

“Hey, making sure your dads are okay is just as important. Besides, my dad will help everyone else in the Frightzone. Right dad?”

Micah gave a smile and thumbs up, “You two go on, meet us back here tonight, and hopefully we’ll reconvene with the other princesses. Without the chips of course.”

Glimmer nodded, walking over to Bow. The two waved before teleporting out of the hideout.

"Alright, everyone else, let's get ready and head out."

⚔

Seeing the Frightzone abandoned was surreal for both Catra and Adora. All that was left was the occasional drone from Prime flying around. Slowly, the group walked across the barren wasteland, cloaked in Melog's illusions.

"It's weird, being back… isn't it?" Adora quietly asked Catra as they stopped behind a wall, "So many memories here…"

"Most of them bad." Catra sighed. She looked up when Adora went quiet, staring at the decimated land with a frown, "Hm…" Catra suddenly smiled, "Hey, I bet I can still beat you to The Forge."

The effect was instant, and Adora perked up, "Uh, yeah because you always cheat!"

The two giggled as Melog re-cloaked them, and they raced across the field to catch up with Netossa, Micah, and Perfuma.

“Scorpia?! Scorpia!”

“What is she doing…?!” Netossa groaned, watching Perfuma aimlessly walk inside.

“Are all of Glimmer’s friends like that..?” Micah whispered to Netossa, who sighed and shook her head.

“Perfuma…!” Adora groaned, racing after her with Catra and Melog only steps behind. The group froze when the green lights suddenly turned on, flickering with traces of red electricity. The lights continued to flicker momentarily, before a blast of energy came from a now destroyed wall as Scorpia stepped into view, green eyes piercing through the shadows.

“Why isn’t she attacking..?” Netossa asked after a moment.

“She recognizes us! I told you she’d never hurt her friends! Scorpia!” Perfuma called, starting to race forward towards her friend.

Adora’s eyes widened when Scorpia’s pincer began to glow, “Perfuma!” She yelled, racing forward and tackling the princess as the blast of lightning flew over their heads.

“She must not be able to tell that it’s us…” Perfuma mourned, frowning.

Catra's eyes widened as she took in the sight of the scorpioni. It had been so long since she'd seen her last, "Whoa…" She gasped when Scorpia suddenly looked at her, diving to hide behind the remnants of a Horde bot. The silence only lasted a few seconds before the bot was suddenly sliced in half by Scorpia's powers, "S-Scorpia..!" Catra exclaimed, quickly backing away. Melog growled, their fur glowing a bright red, "Please- listen I- about everything I- I'm really sorry-!" She screamed when she was suddenly struck by a bolt of electricity, and sent flying out of the room.

"Catra!!" Adora cried, glaring as she grabbed the baton off her belt and extended it.

"Pretty sure she can tell that it's us…" Netossa muttered.

"Still trying to save everyone? What a waste of time, beloved."

Netossa turned, eyes widening when Spinnerella was suddenly behind them, in a tornado of wind, "This one's mine." She growled, racing after her wife.

"Netossa wait!" Adora called only to be held back as Micah cast a quick rune of a shield around them to block Scorpia's next attack.

⚔

Catra cried out as she took a hard landing, crashing to the floor. She groaned, slowly sitting up as Melog came running up to her, “Well… that could have gone better…” She groaned, pushing her bangs out of her face. She huffed when Melog mewled at her, “Hey, I’m working on being a better friend.” Her breath hitched when she suddenly heard water rush through the pipes. Her ear flicked up towards the noise, “Scorpia’s not alone…” She whispered. She quickly got to her feet, gasping when a wave of water suddenly flooded through the corridors. Melog quickly cloaked her as she leaped onto a beam.

Mermista glared, her green eyes scanning for any sight of the magicat, “Stop hiding!” She growled, sending a whip of water around her in a sharp circle, smashing into pipes and denting the old walls.

Catra chose her attacks carefully, making quick swipes at the chip as she leapt across the different beams. She made her first leap for the chip, biting back a yelp when Mermista threw her off her shoulders, “Hiding is pointless!” Mermista yelled, looking around for any signs of movement, “Show yourself and kneel before Horde Prime’s might.”

“Not a chance.” Taking her shot, Catra leapt onto Mermista’s shoulders and knocked her to the ground. She extended her claws, slamming her fit into the chip. Mermista cried out, struggling to get the invisible brunette off of her, “Come on, fight him. You’re the most stubborn out of the princesses I’ve met. You really wanna let him beat your ass like this?”

“Gh…fuck you…” Mermista groaned, a smirk forming on her face.

Melog removed the cloak from Catra when the green faded from Mermista’s eyes. Catra stabbed a claw into the eye of the chip for good measure, glad it only seemed to cause the sparking chip harm, as the princess didn’t react. Slowly, Catra stood up, letting Mermista sit up, the chip’s light fading away for the final time, “What happened…? Catra?” She looked around, “Why am I in the Frightzone?”

“It’s a long story, but I am- on the Rebellion side now so please don’t drown me. Also I saved your life so you owe me.”

Groaning, Mermista got to her feet, “Ughhh man, I’m never living that down.”

Catra shook her head with a chuckle, “Not a chance, fish stick. Now come on, Spinnerella is around here somewhere too I’m sure and so is Scorpia and they’re both still chipped.”

Nodding, Mermista followed Catra down the hall, making a mental note to ask her ever growing list of questions to the others later.

⚔

Adora panted as she raced through the corridors with Micah and Perfuma, Micah doing his best to shield them with his magic as they rushed into a closed hallway, "I can't believe Prime has done this…" Perfuma frowns, "Scorpia is so… she was so fully of light and love and- and he's stripped that away!"

"We'll- we'll find a way to get her back. I know we will." Adora said, placing a hand on her shoulder, "We just need to-"

"Uh- girls?" Micah interrupted, pointing the series of doors in the hallway starting to slam shut.

"Oh no…" Adora sighed, the three taking off again. She spotted a door she knew led to an exit, but it too slammed closed before they get through it, forcing them to run into Hordak's old Sanctum.

It was quiet for a moment, when the staircase suddenly lit up, drawing a gasp from the trio as they turned, eyes widening when the throne fully lit up, revealing Horde Prime himself, staring down at them.

"Hello again, Adora."

The blonde's breath hitched. She immediately backed away, gasping when the door slammed shut, "Wh- What are you doing here…?"

The three looked as Scorpia slowly walked out of the shadows from the side of the staircase. She raised her pincer, electricity racing through the thick wires on the floor that suddenly shot off of the floor and restrained all three of them where they stood around their waists and wrists.

"I thought it was time that I see for myself what makes Etheria so… special. Why my little brother took such an interest in it." He slowly rose, before descending the stairs, "Starting with his- amusing little stronghold."

"I- I told you before, you're not getting She-Ra..!" Adora gasped, struggling against the wires.

"Oh, my sweet child," Prime smirked, grabbing Adora's chin and making her cry out in panic, "I have no use for you, not anymore." He released her, motioning to the sanctum around them, "My little brother's research has given me everything I need to know." He smirked, "Not that She-Ra is any use to you either."

Adora's chest felt tight, her breaths coming in short heaves as she tried to stop herself from trembling.

"Do you take me for a fool? Do you think I'm not aware of what my technology has done to you? You have no more access to She-Ra than I do."

“I- I…! You- you’re lying!” She tried, rapidly trying to blink the forming tears away.

“The technology on your planet is crude and outdated. It will be mere child’s play to bypass its defenses and take the heart of the weapon for myself. With, or without you.” Prime stepped back towards the throne, nudging Scorpia forward towards the captives, “As always, your childish fixation on saving everyone has made you nothing but a martyr that will be faceless to history. Your emotional connections have made you weak.”

“You’re wrong!” Perfuma suddenly yelled, glaring at the tyrant, “There’s power, real power in love and friendship!”

“And what would you know about real power?”

“Friendship isn’t a weakness,” Perfuma glared, trying to ignore Scorpia’s pincers as they started to glow, “It’s my greatest strength! And it’s Scorpia’s too!”

“I’ve heard enough.” Prime spared Scorpia a glance before starting back up the stairs towards the throne, “Dispose of them. Now.”

“Scorpia… you can break through this. I know you can!” Perfuma pleaded, watching with teary eyes.

Adora looked around desperately for anything that could help them despite the panic attack she was trying to fight through. Her eyes widening when she saw a familiar tail swaying from a high beam. She gasped when a wave of water suddenly shot over the stairwell and knocked Prime off the side into a far wall.

Catra leapt down to the floor, racing forward to put herself between Scorpia and the others, "Scorpia please! They care about you. I care about you. Don't let him control you anymore."

Scorpia stood still, just staring at Catra for a moment. Just long enough for Mermista to shoot a strip of water into the chip, making Scorpia cry out and fall to her knees.

Micah used the time to draw a rune on the floor with his foot, stepping on it to activate it and dispel the restraints. He immediately wrapped his arms around Adora, catching her from collapsing herself, "Hey, breathe Adora…"

Perfuma rushed over to Scorpia and Catra, "Scorpia!?"

"Hey! Is she good or not?" Mermista yelled, "I only have so much water to hold this freak back!" She whipped another wave at Prime to knock him back down.

Scorpia groaned, opening her eyes, the green finally gone, "What happened- Wildcat? Perfuma?"

“She’s good!” Micah replied, rubbing Adora’s back. The blonde was still struggling to pull herself together.

Glimmer suddenly teleported into the room, having been called by Catra from the prison block monitors before she had rushed to the sanctum with Mermista. She looked around before ushering Micah and Adora over to Scorpia, Catra, and Perfuma, “Mermista!” She called. The princess rushed over, grabbing onto Catra’s shoulder as they were quickly teleported out of the sanctum and back to the camp, “Get Entrapta to start working on getting the chips off, I’m going back to get Netossa and- hopefully Spinnerella.”

When Glimmer reappeared in the Frightzone, now on the roof, she smiled when she saw Netossa hugging her wife close, “I got her….” She whispered.

Nodding, Glimmer teleported the three of them back to camp.

⚔

The camp was quiet for a few hours, aside from Entrapta rambling into her recorder about her progress in removing the now disabled chips.

“I can’t believe we did it…” Catra sighed, her arm around Adora, who had calmed down but had been quiet ever since, curled up

against the brunette, “So, how was the trip to Bow’s dads? Find them?”

Glimmer smiled, nodding, “They’re hiding out in the Crystal Castle. They actually found something that I think will be helpful.”

“There’s a failsafe for the Heart of Etheria.” Bow took over, making Adora perk up, “We don’t know entirely what it is, but according to the recording we heard it’s capable of shutting off the Heart for good.”

“A failsafe…” Adora mumbled, smiling, “That’s… that’s amazing..! We can still save everyone, and we can stop Prime for good! Where is it?”

“That’s… that’s what we aren’t sure yet. They said it was in a place called Arxia. Other than that…” Bow shrugged, “We got nothing.”

“I know where it is.”

The haunting voice made everyone tense and turn towards the camp entrance, where Shadow Weaver slowly walked inside, her hands clasped together in front of her.

Catra tensed, her pupils shrinking to slits as she stared at the woman with hatred. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow shared unsure

expressions, the blonde gently taking Catra’s hand to try and keep her calm.

“We have to go to Mystacor.”

Chapter End Notes

I would love to hear what you think! Remember, the next chapter is the Failsafe, and Adora has no access to She-Ra :)

It Takes Two

Chapter Summary

> Catra turned to the crystal, staring at it as an idea came to her. She would never let Adora walk in there alone, the literal weight of the world on her shoulders, but perhaps…
>
> "Can two people accept it?"

Chapter Notes

> I have a feeling you're all going to love this chapter. I've had this particular part planned since like- chapter there of this AU lol
>
> Lots of justice and love is forming, and I cannot wait to share the final chapter with you all! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Wait so hold on, you’ve been in Mystacor this entire time?” Micah raised an eyebrow, crossing his arms.

“Well, while they were all busy traipsing around in space, *some* of us have been trying to stop the Heart of Etheria from falling into Prime’s hands.” Shadow Weaver clasped her hands together, “And I discovered the same thing you did: rumors of a Failsafe that will destroy the restraints the First One’s built, and set the stolen magic free.”

“Are- Are you serious!?” Glimmer glares, her voice echoing off the cavern walls, “After everything that happened last time, you’re *still* going after the Heart of Etheria?!”

“Yes, we are aware of what *you* tried. This is different. The Failsafe will return the magic to the planet itself.”

Glimmer tensed, her hands balling into fists.

Micah sighed, running his fingers through his hair, “As much as I hate to agree with her, she is the lesser of two evils…” He huffed, “Even if it’s not by much.” He then muttered.

“At least you admit she’s evil.” Catra sneered.

“You’re one to talk aren’t you?” Shadow Weaver remarked, making Catra tense and her claws extend. Adora quickly rested a hand on the brunette’s shoulder and guided her to sit back down.

“Enough. Tell us what you know about the Failsafe. What makes you think its in Mystacor?” Adora narrowed her eyes.

“As any good sorcerer knows, Mystacor was built on the ruins of an ancient First One’s citadel. There are many secret passageways and catacombs hidden beneath Mystacor, and within those halls lie an ancient artifact known as Crystal of Arxia, hidden there by a group of traitorous First Ones. Reaching it, however, won’t be easy, but I’ve spent my entire life studying the secrets of Mystacor. I can get us in.”

Adora hardened her glare, “If you figured this out on your own, why come back here? Why do you need us at all?”

“Because Mystacor is controlled by Castaspella and other sorcerers, which as you may recall, is controlled by Horde Prime. While their powers may be little in comparison to myself at my full potential, I have basically no access to any of my powers thanks to someone who stole my runestone.”

Catra smirked.

“Actually it’s- it’s kinda my runestone…” Scorpia mumbled. Perfuma smiled and rested a hand on her shoulder.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes, “Whatever.”

Sighing, Adora hugged herself, “Well, it’s the only lead we have.” She glanced towards Catra, who stared at her for a moment before groaning.

“Ugh, fine. It’s all we got. Let’s get this over with. It needs to be a stealth mission.”

“Don’t worry about camp,” Mermista cut in, approaching with Sea Hawk by her side. Like Scorpia and Spinnerella, she had a bandage on the back of her neck from when Entrapta had

removed her chip, “We’ll hold down the fort until you guys get back.”

“Thanks, Mermista.” Adora smiled, “Alright, let’s get ready and get out of here.”

⚔

The group slowly slipped onto the grounds of Mystacor, all cloaked in Melog’s illusionary magic. They crouched next to a boulder as one of the elder sorcerers passed by them, their eyes bright green. The sight made Adora tense. She could still the angry crowd of whispers in her head that had taken over her mind when she was chipped. She could only imagine everyone else that was chipped was going through the same thing she had.

Once the sorceress walked away, the group hurried forward, slipping through the open doors of the fortress. They ventured part way down the hallway before Shadow Weaver suddenly stopped and thrust her arm out in front of them. Slowly, Castaspella walked in front of the door at the end of the hallway. She’s frowning, her eyes glowing green. Glimmer tenses, looking up at Micah when he placed an arm on her shoulder. A tear run down his face that he quickly wipes away. When Castaspella strides off, Shadow Weaver waves them forward. They run down the hall, stopping at the entrance to a round purple room. Adora recognized it as the room they performed the eclipse ceremonies in.

Catra glanced around, “No sorcerers here. Looks like we’re—” She gasped when Shadow Weaver suddenly grabbed her, clasping a hand over her mouth.

“Keep your voice down..!”

“Don’t touch me!” Catra gasped, jerking herself away from the woman as Melog dropped their invisibility shield.

A sorcerer had appeared and casts a quick spell at the group. Adora rushed forward, “For the honor of Grayskull!” She yelled out, her eyes widening when a faint illusion of her sword flickered before disappearing, and she remembered “Crap…” She yelped, diving behind the same column Catra had gone to when a second spell is fired her way.

Micah quickly drew a rune and tossed it at the sorcerer, rendering them unconscious.

“We have to hurry.” Shadow Weaver whispered, the group rushing forward into the next hallway, where all of the statues of past sorcerers stood. They stopped in front what appeared to be a regular wall at the end of the statues, “We’re here. Follow my lead.”

“Would a simple please kill you?” Micah rolled his eyes, but followed his ex-mentor in a spell, sending a rune of a diamond into a matching shape in the wall, causing it to glow and spread

through the rest of the indents in the wall. The walls fell back along the glowing lines to reveal a doorway to a hidden passage, and the group hurried inside, shrouding them in darkness once the doorway fell closed. Glimmer was quick to cast a simple light spell to guide their way.

"Nice thinking." Micah smiled, his daughter blushing lightly in reply.

Adora glanced at Catra, who still looked shaken up. She gently reached out and touched her shoulder, "Hey are you—"

Catra jumped, "I'm fine. Sorry. I just…"

"There's no time to waste. The news of our presence will have reached the others by now after that… disturbance."

Catra glared, trying to ignore the memories that flooded back to the front of her mind as Shadow Weaver towered over her. Adora glared, taking Catra's hand and pulling her away from the sorceress, "Then we should focus." Adora snapped, hurrying forward with Catra to catch up with the others.

"What is all this…?" Bow asked, looking at the various drawings covering the walls. He gently ran his hand over it.

“We're on the right path. The Crystal of Arxia was rumored to be the key to reaching deep magic within Etheria. Many have tried, and failed, to find it. But those who hungered for more power have long sought other ways to obtain the deep magic...with disastrous results.” Micah explained, glaring daggers at Shadow Weaver, who rolled her eyes and sighed.

“The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake that I have paid the price for. Honestly, I don’t see why you keep bringing it up.”

“How about because you almost got me killed that day, or the fact that you did get so many wonderful and powerful sorcerers killed that day.” Micah glared, his hands set in tight fists.

“Well if you hadn’t broken the connection then it would have worked. You’ve always been an exceptional sorcerer, even back then.”

“I was a child! And you have no way to prove it would or would not have worked regardless of whether my connection was maintained or not.”

Shadow Weaver went to rebuttal when she noticed a purple emblem on the floor, “Adora wait-!”

“What?” Adora stepped on the rune, causing a ring of fire to draw up around her.

“Adora!” Catra yelled, racing forward and leaping into the blaze, falling out seconds later with her arms wrapped around Adora.

“I’m okay..! I’m okay..” Adora blinked, sharing a smile with Catra before a smirk took over, “Did you just jump into fire for me?”

“Ugh- I- shut up!!” Catra groaned, getting to her feet and looking away as she held out a hand for Adora, who was giggling.

“You did!”

Glimmer slowly approached the fire, easily passing her hand through it, “It’s an illusion.”

“*Some* of the fire is an illusion, but some of it is real. You all need to be careful.”

Everyone slowly passed through, starting down another hallway. Adora walked in last, biting her lip as she stared at her hands. Her mind was still reeling around her failed transformation just a few minutes prior.

"I see you and Catra have grown close again."

Though she tensed, Adora held a firm tone. "That's none of your

business." She replied as she shot the sorceress a side glare.

"But it is. I've been back less than a day and all you've done is let her distract you-"

"-Catra is *not* a distraction!"

Catra paused as she rounded the corner, ears perking up. She never thought she would see the day where Adora *actually* stood up to Shadow Weaver.

"Adora you cannot be so naive as to-"

"-Shut. Up!" Adora snapped, slapping the sorceress' hand away when she tried to cup her cheek, "Catra risked her life to save me and Glimmer from Prime. All she's done since I got her back is help and protect me and our camp. If *you* are so naive that you'll ignore that it's clear *you* are the distraction. If it weren't for her, I would still be chipped right now, so for once in your life, put aside your unnecessary hatred of her, and focus on the task at hand! I may not know why I can't transform or- or if I'm losing her. I- I don't know, but I do know that of all people Catra is not and never will be the problem."

Shadow Weaver stared, speechless as Adora turned on her heel and continued down the hall.

The blonde flinched when she bumped into a teary eyed Catra, "Oh- Catra did you-" She gasped when she was suddenly pulled into a passionate hug. Slowly, Adora wrapped her arms around Catra, smiling.

"Thank you, Adora..." Catra whispered.

"Just- doing what I should have a long time ago..."

Shadow Weaver rounded the corner, Catra casting her a glare before flipping her off, "Come on.." She took Adora's hand, leaving

a silently fuming Shadow Weaver as they hurried to catch up with the others.

⚔

The group slowly crossed the threshold into the massive cavern, where a large crystal stood, towering over them at the top of a short platform.

"This is the Failsafe?" Glimmer asked, still in shock.

Bow felt a sense of unease, "It's- bigger, than I thought it'd be. How are we gonna get this to the Heart?"

"The Failsafe is a code. It's stored inside the crystals."

Adora tilted her head, "So, how do we-"

"It needs a password." Shadow Weaver took Adora's hand and pressed it to the crystal, "I think you already know what it is."

"We're friends of Mara." Adora said after a deep breath.

The crystal suddenly split into three, forming a circle around an elevated platform. First One's writing showed up on the crystal.

"Someone needs to go inside and.. accept the Failsafe? What does that mean?"

"It means the Failsafe must be bonded to a willing soul and carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in ordered to be deployed."

"And we're sure that's-- safe?" Bow asked, unsure.

"We can't turn back now, we're so close!"

Adora looked back towards the Failsafe, starting to step forward. Catra growled and raced forward, grabbing the blonde's hand, "Adora don't."

"Catra- Someone needs to needs to accept the Failsafe." Shadow Weaver glared, "She needs to-"

"-Then *you* do it." Catra glared, "Why does it have to be Adora? What aren't you telling us?"

Shadow Weaver scoffed, "You're being paranoid."

"Answer, the question." Micah demanded.

"Whoever uses the Failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed. That much raw magical power would burn any mere mortal apart. None of us are strong enough." The sorceress slowly explained.

"But She-Ra is."

"Only She-Ra can hope to survive the process. No one else can do it."

Adora suddenly laughed, her tone dark in a way few had ever seen or heard from the blonde, "There's only one problem, Shadow Weaver…" She suddenly turned and glared at her, wiping her eyes, "She-Ra is gone!"

"…What?"

"Have you been drinking that much?!" Glimmer yelled, "Of course you wouldn't have realized that, but that's not even the whole point! You were just gonna sacrifice Adora!"

"You were planning this all along weren't you?!" Micah crossed his arms.

"There's no way we're going to risk Adora like that!" Bow added.

Catra turned to the crystal, staring at it as an idea came to her. She would never let Adora walk in there alone, the literal weight of the world on her shoulders, but perhaps…

"Can two people accept it?"

"Wait what?" Adora turned to the brunette, her eyes widening.

The others turned to look at them.

"All that power is too much for one person, but what if it was split between two?" Catra turned to Shadow Weaver when there was no response, "Well?"

"I don't know."

She scoffed, "Great, useful as ever."

"Catra you can't seriously be suggesting.. It could hurt you!"

"It could hurt you! Look, neither of us want to see the other do it alone, but we always said nothing bad can happen as long as we have each other." She paused momentarily, blinking away tears as she grasped both of Adora's hands in hers, "I-.. I've never cared about the risks we take as long as we took them together. So..?" She squeezed her hands, a sad smile on her face.

Eyes welling up, Adora nodded, squeezing her hands as they both looked towards the towering crystals.

Before they could move forward, the doorway was blown apart as sorcerers entered the room, all chipped and immediately trying to

attack, sending spells to restrain the others. Glimmer and Micah began to fight back with their own magic while Bow fired his net arrows.

Managing to weave out of the way, Catra and Adora hurried up the stairs onto the platform, hand in hand.

The platform below them begins to glow, magical energy beginning to flow through both of them as they're lifted into the air.

Grunts and whimpers escape both of them, Adora grinding her teeth together while Catra squeezed one eye closed. Still, they smiled at each other, intertwining their fingers.

Suddenly, they heard Glimmer cry out as she was blasted with a spell and sent flying back against the wall.

Bow wasn't fairing well either, all of his arrows were being destroyed by magic as he shot them.

Adora gasped, eyes glowing. She reached a hand out, a slimmer version of She-Ra's sword appearing.

Catra's eyes began glowing as well. She didn't know why, but she felt compelled to stretch her arm and face her palm out towards the battle at the same time as Adora aimed her sword. Together, they sent a blast of energy and magic strong enough to dispel any of the chipped sorceress' spells and send them into the wall or to the floor, trapped where they couldn’t hurt anyone else.

"Adora? Catra?!" Glimmer exclaimed, getting up and rushing to the stairs just as they descended, still holding hands.

Both of them had what looked like half of a heart with some First One's lines through it glowing on their chests.

They looked at them before looking at each other, suddenly

feeling shy and flustered.

"I can't believe you two did that..." The queen sighed

“At least it worked.” Catra sighed, partially relieved. Adora wouldn’t be doing this alone. They were together, no matter what happened from now on.

"Come on, we need to get out of here." Glimmer groaned, the group rushing out of the room, leaving the unconscious sorcerers behind.

⚔

Once they returned to the camp and ate, everyone slowly made their way to their mats. Adora and Catra were laying on their mats, which they’d pushed together, and were laying down on their sides facing each other. Noticing her pinned ears, Adora slowly reaches a hand out and takes Catra’s. The two tensed, eyes widening when their chests started to glow again.

“Whoa…” Adora blushes, “Is that gonna happen every time we…?”

Catra bit her lip. She reached out and poked her finger against Adora’s forehead, and sure enough, their chests started glowing again, “Well. That’s- something.”

Adora slowly smiled. She waited for Catra to remove her finger before scooting closer to the brunette, before wrapping an arm around her, and the Failsafe started glowing on them both once again.

"Adora it's gonna be hard to sleep with the dumb lights in our faces."

Adora pulled the blankets over their shoulders before snuggling in further, "Fixed."

"My hero." Catra rolled her eyes, a light blush forming on her cheeks. Adora giggled, causing the brunette to blush deeper. She finally gave in after a few minutes, letting Adora wrap her arms around her. Despite the light that shone from under the blanket, the two were soon able to fall asleep in the safety of each others arms.

Chapter End Notes

AHHH, okay only one chapter left!!

I can't wait to hear what you think about this one!

From the Heart

Chapter Summary

> “So… why here? And how are we supposed to get out?” Bow felt his chest tighten.
>
> “When I broke the sword. I thought I could make my own destiny. Then Prime chipped me and tried to take my right to choose for myself. When we got to the Failsafe, and Shadow Weaver told us the truth… I…” Tears run down her face as she struggles to get the words out, “I always thought I would die for this war. I’ve never been able to see an ending where I came out alive. But then Catra and I took the Failsafe together. I’m still scared, and I’m confused, and I still don’t know how this is going to end, but…”
>
> Catra took Adora’s hand. She was crying, “Adora…"

Chapter Notes

> I won't lie to you, I am so relieved this fic is done. I really enjoyed writing it and experimenting with what would happen, but let's be honest when I say that I just rewrote the last two episodes in one. I hope I did the end of this fic justice though, and I really hope you enjoy it! I'll be diving into finishing Blindsided now, as I really want to finish that before I post my Big Bang fic in May, so I can then bring a brand new AU for you guys (trust me, there are a lot).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sighed as she stared at herself in the mirror. It was late, or early depending on how you looked at it. Still, they needed to end this war today, and the sooner they started, the quicker it would be over with. She extended her hand towards the mirror, trying in vain to summon her sword. She quietly groaned, her eyes widening when she could have sworn she saw Prime laughing at

her in the mirror. She gasps, stumbling back and falling onto the cot behind her, panting softly.

"Adora..?"

Flinching, she glanced behind her. Catra was standing there, her hand on the curtain that had been shielding Adora from the rest of the camp, "Hey, Catra." She smiled slightly, "Everything okay?"

"I should be asking you that. I woke up and you were gone. What are you doing…?"

"Just…" Sighing, Adora took a deep breath, focusing on Catra, "I was trying to summon my sword again. Didn't work, of course…"

Frowning, Catra took a seat by Adora, wrapping an arm around her shoulder, causing the Failsafes on their chests to start glowing, "Hopefully once we destroy the Heart with the Failsafe, you'll get She-Ra back. And- even if you don't, you're still a hero, and you've been able to protect your friends without her."

"But I should still have her..!" Adora teared up, quickly wipes her eyes, "Prime's stupid virus I- I just feel like he- he destroyed her…"

Catra slowly reached out, taking Adora's hands in her own, "He's taken so much from so many people. From me, from you. " She

starts as the Failsafe started glowing, “So let’s get rid of him. For good.”

Slowly, Adora smirked and nodded. She gave Catra’s hand a gentle squeeze before pulling the brunette to her feet. They walked out of the curtained room together, approaching the light rune the Alliance was surrounding. Channeling her emotions, Adora pushed her confidence and anger to the front, ready as she could be to face her friends and do her best to prepare them for the day ahead, “Prime is getting closer every day to figuring out how to access the Heart of Etheria. If he succeeds, he can use it to destroy worlds, galaxies, maybe even the entire universe. The Failsafe is our only chance at stopping him. We may have saved our friends, but Prime still has most of Etheria chipped. His hold over them grows stronger every day. If we don't free them now, we might lose them forever. Prime holds every advantage in this fight. He'll be ready for us. But we have a plan. Entrapta?”

The scientist leapt to her feet, a bright smile on her face as she showed off her trackerpad screen, “I finally succeeded in cracking Prime's signal pattern. If I get access to his Spire network, I can use it to broadcast a jamming frequency that will disable all of the chips on Etheria, freeing everyone at once!”

“I need you all to get Entrapta to the Spire, to distract Prime’s forces so she can jam the signal. Catra and I are gonna take the Failsafe to the Heart and destroy it. We’re going to make sure Prime can never hurt anyone ever again. We’re ending this today. No matter what.”

While the group prepared for their mission, Adora and Catra slipped out of the camp, hand in hand. They shared a look, before

starting to walk forward, only to stop when Glimmer and Bow appeared in front them by teleport, "You two weren't seriously going to just run off to the Heart without us, were you?" Glimmer asked.

"Are you two sure you should come? It's going to be dangerous and-" Adora's words were cut off by Glimmer and Bow wrapping their arms around her and Catra.

"Adora. We are the Best Friend Squad. Whatever we find, we'll face and fix it together." Bow assured. Though she sighed, Adora nodded.

"Okay."

⚔

The four slowly entered the Crystal Castle, sticking close together as they approached a hologram that stood alone in the center of the room near a wall.

"Warning. Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time."

"We're friends of Mara." Adora spoke clearly, the Failsafe glowing off both her and Catra. The hologram began to glow gold as it

spoke again.

"Welcome, friends of Mara."

Behind it, the glowing continued and a door formed, opening to reveal a long hallway. Slowly, the four approached, crossing the threshold and beginning the journey down towards the Heart of Etheria.

Silence sat between them for a while, tension walking between them as they watched First One's symbols appear and disappear across the walks at will.

"Are… are you guys scared?" Glimmer suddenly asked, looking at the two, who shared a look.

"I just- I really hope this works." Adora says, squeezing Catra's hand.

"Me too." Catra whispered.

The four tensed when the walls seemed to shift around them, the hallway around them seeming to shift like it was flickering through a slide show, "What's happening?" Bow asked.

“I think this place can still project memories…” Adora frowned, seeing slips of the Frightzone, Brightmoon, and the Whispering Woods in random points.

Catra’s tail fluffed, she tightened her hold on Adora’s hand, “We need to be careful.”

Adora pulled Catra forward, every fiber of her being wishing she had She-Ra, that she had been able to take the Failsafe herself. She hated that Catra had put herself in so much danger for no reason.

It was her job to be She-Ra.

It was her job to protect Etheria.

It was her job to save everyone. She was supposed to stop Prime, to-

“Adora?”

The blonde opened her eyes, blinking and looking around. They were in the Whispering Woods, or at least, it looked like they were. She noticed the others looking behind her and turned. Her eyes widened when she saw her old sword, perched in the branches, just like the day she found it so many years ago.

“What is going on?” Glimmer breathed.

“I think I know.” Adora takes a deep breath, “This place is responding to my memories. I think I’m doing this.”

“So… why here? And how are we supposed to get out?” Bow felt his chest tighten.

“When I broke the sword. I thought I could make my own destiny. Then Prime chipped me and tried to take my right to choose for myself. When we got to the Failsafe, and Shadow Weaver told us the truth… I…” Tears run down her face as she struggles to get the words out, “I always thought I would die for this war. I’ve never been able to see an ending where I came out alive. But then Catra and I took the Failsafe together. I’m still scared, and I’m confused, and I still don’t know how this is going to end, but…”

Catra took Adora’s hand. She was crying, “Adora… I…-”

The four cried out when green wires of energy broke into the illusion, surrounding the branches holding the sword but not quite able to get to it, “What is happening up there!?” Glimmer’s eyes widened.

“It has to be Prime.. What if he’s hacked into the planet? He’s gonna get the Heart!” Bow panicked.

Adora and Catra shared a look before looking to their friends, “Sparkles, you and Bow should get back up there, make sure Entrapta was able to break the chip signal. Adora and I can handle this.”

“What? There’s no way we’re-!”

“Catra’s right. We need to go the rest of the way alone. The others need your help more.” Adora confirmed.

Sighing, Glimmer nodded, stepping back with Bow after hugging Catra and Adora briefly, “Take care of her, Horde Scum.”

Catra smiled, nodding, “That’s the plan, Sparkles.”

Adora and Catra watched the two teleport away before turning back to the sword. Adora took Catra’s hand before reaching out and grabbing the sword. A bright light came forward, blinding the two momentarily.

⚔

When they reappeared near the spire, Glimmer looked around, smiling when Melog ran up to them from around the corner, mewling to try and get them to follow them, "Go help the princesses. I'll go help with the signal-!" Bow flinched when he was suddenly pulled into Glimmer's arms.

"Bow-! I love you! I love you…"

A warm smile formed on his face. He gently kissed her forehead, blushing, "I love you too."

Glimmer slowly stepped back. She watched Bow run towards the spire before teleporting to the others to help fight the clones.

She cried out as she appeared, slamming her fist into the ground and incapacitating every clone surrounding her. She smirked as she stood up, briefly hugging Frosta when she rushed over, "Glimmer!"

"Did you miss me?"

"Yes, but also, behind you!"

Glimmer turned, quickly drawing a rune and knocking back the clone coming for her, "We just need to hold them off long enough for Catra and Adora to unleash the Failsafe!"

“Everyone just stick close together. We got this!” Perfuma smiled, using her magic to block a trio of clones.

Everyone continued to play on the defense, praying that it would be over soon.

⚔

When Catra and Adora opened their eyes, they were standing on a cliff overlooking Etheria. Magic was reigning everywhere, and a peaceful aura surrounded them, reminding the duo what they were fighting for. Why they needed to stop Prime from taking the Heart, Etheria, and the rest of the universe.

“It’s… beautiful.”

“We’ll have this. The Failsafe will destroy the Heart and- and Etheria will be free. Its magic will be free.”

The two smiled at each other for a moment, before the illusion was disrupted by Prime’s virus.

“Hello, Little Sister.”

They tensed, slowly turning around, wide eyed when they saw Prime standing there.

"So this is where you've run to hide."

Adora was the first to glare, "You're not here. You can't stop us!"

Catra clenched her hands into fists.

Prime looked around, taking in the warped sight of Etheria around them, "It's a beautiful wish, but there's no future for you two. For any of Etheria. Not without my hand over it, molding it into my image. My light."

The two gasped when a scream of a creature was heard in the distance.

"A parting gift from the First One's. Their old security system. It's capable of taking out one even as strong as She-Ra. Though, it doesn't seem like you have her anymore, do you Little Sister?"

"I am not your sister!" Adora snapped.

Prime merely chuckled, "You'll never make it to the Heart. Little Sister's own people have made sure of that. Goodbye, my oldest

enemy.” Prime said simply before his hologram disappeared.

Catra and Adora gasped when the illusion of Etheria fell away, leaving them in a room with a large monster looming tall over them, one of the monster’s arms lunged towards them, missing narrowly when they parted for it to slash the wall between them, “Stay back! I’ll handle this thing!”

“Catra no!” Adora grabbed Catra’s hand, the symbols on their chests immediately glowing. The beast then paused, like it was in a trance.

“What’s it doing..?”

Adora’s eyes widened when she realized what was happening, “It recognizes the Failsafe…!”

Catra blinked, looking back at the creature as it retreated, curling up in the middle of the room. Adora remembered when she first became She-Ra, how she had tamed the monster that had attacked her, Glimmer, and Bow.

“I… wow. That is so embarrassing for Prime. Did that really just happen..?” Catra snorts.

“I guess it’s a good thing he doesn’t understand Etheria as much as he thinks he does.” Adora smiled, “Come on, let’s get to the

Heart.”

The two ran down a passageway that extended off the side of the room. They shared another smile as they pressed forward. Even despite the sickly green that was taking over the walls around them, they could see the literal light at the end of the tunnel. There was nothing stopping them now.

It wasn’t a long walk before they began to approach the Heart. The only indication a war was even happening was the occasional sound of thunder and magic in the far distance above them. Though that sound was immediately overwhelmed by the raw magic of the Heart as soon as they stepped on the platform below it.

For a moment, they simply stared at it, not sure what to say as the reality of the situation came crashing down on both of them.

“Adora…”

“Catra…”

They looked at each other, the sight of the other drowning out all other sight and sound in the room. And for a moment, it was just them.

“We’re really doing this huh..?”

“Guess we are…”

“Adora…?”

“Yes..?”

“Before we activate the Failsafe I… you said before that you thought breaking the sword meant you could choose your own destiny, but I know you. No matter what events led up to getting the Failsafe, to getting to this moment, you would have accepted it, with or without someone else. Without me. You’d say that you had to do it, that you had to be the hero that saved the day. Even if it meant sacrificing yourself.”

Adora tried to blink away the tears in her eyes, but they rolled down her face anyway, “Do.. Do you remember on Prime’s ship when I was… chipped. Do you remember when you told me I spent my life listening to everyone else, when you asked if I could do something for once that was just for me?” Catra slowly nodded, her chest aching as she thought about everything that had been said that day, “Remember when I said what I wanted didn’t matter?”

Catra furrowed her eyebrows, “It does matter. Whatever you want it-…” She took a deep breath, “What *do* you want, Adora?”

Adora smiled sadly, “That’s just it… I finally figured out the answer to that question.”

Eyes widening slightly, Catra stared at her as Adora slowly took her hands, squeezing them gently.

“You… all I’ve ever wanted was you. And even if today… if we don’t get to walk out of here, I can’t let this end without you knowing that you’re the one that holds my heart.”

Tears ran down Catra’s face, a smile forming with a blush to match, “Adora I… that’s all I’ve ever wanted to hear. To know that you want me the same way I want you… I..” Catra stared in disbelief, “You…you really love me..?”

Adora couldn’t stop the chuckle that came out, “Yes. So much. I love you so much, Catra.”

“I love you too…” Catra whispered the words, but Adora heard them more clearly than anything else.

Slowly, the two closed the remaining distance between them, their lips all but crashing together. With their eyes closed, they failed to see the Failsafe glow brighter than it ever had before, a rainbow light encasing them and taking over the virus that Prime had tried to infect the Heart with.

Catra opened her eyes when she felt herself be moved. She gasped when she saw Adora, now She-Ra, holding her close. The look was different. She looked more like Adora, like She-Ra had formed around her instead of the other way around, “Adora…” She breathed when they finally broke the kiss, “You… you’re…”

Adora looked down, smiling when she realized she had finally transformed again. She laughed, “I’m She-Ra!”

Catra giggled, “You are, and you’re beautiful.” Her eyes locked on the tiara on her head, it resembled something familiar to her, but she couldn’t place what exactly at the moment, “Shall we go show Prime he’s done for?”

Now smirking, Adora nodded. They made their way out of the Heart through an opening that had formed for them, bringing them out onto a cliff near the spire. The rest of the Alliance gasped, smiling when they saw the couple approaching. They were surrounded by magic, glowing as they held the power of the Heart within them.

When they stopped walking, the forming grass that followed paused with them. Adora summoned her sword, she and Catra gripping onto the handle together as they looked up at the Velvet Glove looming above them. Sharing a smile, they cried out, unleashing the full magic of Etheria, blasting it from the sword and onto the mother ship. Lush greenery and landscape quickly began to take it over, destroying any tech that remained inside.

Once done, they flipped the sword and drove it into the ground, sending the magic back into the planet and covering it with the life, magic, and greenery it had once possessed, and now held once again. The glow finally faded from the couple as they turned their attention to Horde Prime, who had possessed Hordak and was on the ground, glaring at them. Catra moved towards him, but Adora stopped her with a gentle touch to her shoulder. She shook her head, before walking over, towering over Prime.

"This is not the end. It may be rubble and dark now, but Prime will rise again. Prime will always return to take what is his."

"No." Adora said simply, glaring at him, "You've done enough. It's time for you to go." She grabbed onto Hordak's face, glowing as she closed her eyes and let her healing magic flow through them. Hordak cried out as Prime's virus, his essence was expelled and destroyed for good.

When Adora pulled away, Hordak stared at her for a few moments, "I.. I remember you."

Adora smiled. She stepped back when Entrapta rushed over to hug him, immediately beginning to ramble about something to do with tech. She slowly backed away, giggling when she bumped into Catra. She grabbed her and swung her around, making the magicat squeal and laugh as she was pulled into the blonde's arms. She-Ra faded away, leaving Adora in her place. She laughed when Catra kissed her again. She cupped the brunette's face, letting their foreheads rest together.

“We did it… he’s gone…” Adora gasped.

“Good riddance.” Catra replied with a purr.

The couple yelped when they were suddenly tackled by Bow and Glimmer, the four sliding slightly down the hill in a group hug as they clung to each other.

“I can’t believe it’s over…!” Glimmer gasps, staring at the bright sky, her eyes sparkling.

“Me either… what are we gonna do now?” Catra asked.

“A lot of cleaning up, rebuilding, probably have to relocate a bunch of clones?” Bow shrugged, laughing when Glimmer lightly smacked his shoulder.

Adora looked up, watching the sky for a moment, “We could bring magic back to the universe.”

“Sounds like a Best Friend Squad trip waiting to happen.” Glimmer smirked.

The four slowly got off the ground, hugging each other again, “Well then, what do you guys say to one more road trip?”

“Sounds awesome!”

“Of course I’m going with you, dummy.”

“Then let’s do this. Together.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I would love to hear what you think! <3

Again, I know this was just rewriting the ending but that's what happens when you write canon divergence fics sometimes. The end felt fitting to me, and I think it turned out nice! :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!